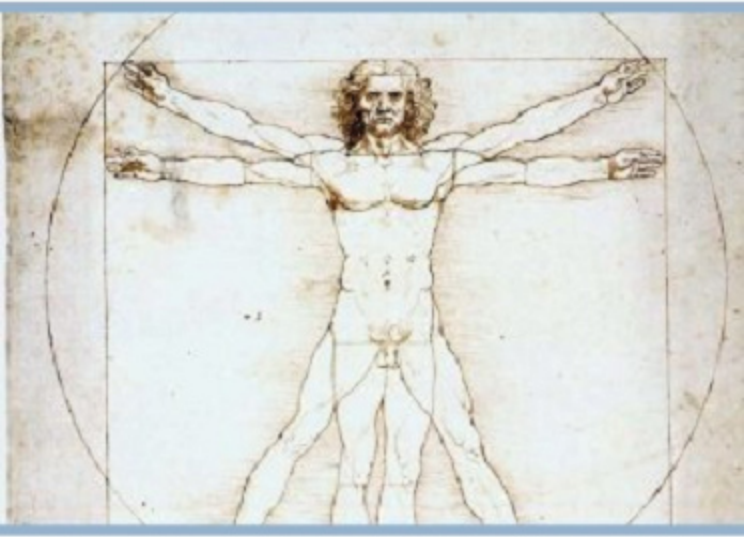
Cheat Codes For Life



How to Achieve Anything With the Technologies of Success

Robert Crayola

CHEAT CODES FOR LIFE:

How to Achieve ANYTHING

With the Technologies of Success

Robert Crayola

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BY ROBERT CRAYOLA

Books

Cheat Codes for Life: How to Achieve ANYTHING With the Technologies of Success

Dr. Jew

William Blake's Songs of Innocence and Experience: Illustrated by Robert Crayola (*with poems by William Blake*)

Short Texts

Prayer Magic: Conversations with Reality

Blog

http://cutup.livejournal.com/

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INTRODUCTION

"Research your own experiences for the truth, absorb what is useful, reject what is useless, add what is specifically your own." – Jiddu Krishnamurti

I've tried to write this book many times. I never finished the job because I wanted perfection, completion, and always found more to include. There was information I had lightly investigated, things that were obviously important, but which I wasn't prepared to fit into the larger puzzle. I suppose I could keep writing this book for the rest of my life and only pass it on to be published when I've learned and experienced all that can be contained in one human life. But rather than wait till I'm dead, I forced myself to come up with a book NOW. I gave myself 30 days to put it together and include everything I could at this moment in my existence. It may not be beautifully written. That's okay. There are plenty of beautifully written books elsewhere. And I'll doubtless revise and expand it as I continue to grow. However, in its current form, flawed though it may be, I think it's packed with valuable information and resources to make your life incredible. If just one reader gets insight or benefit, I'll be happy. Honestly though: I think everyone will find something to help them grow in these pages. Where you will find it… I don't know, but I tried to make this book the most valuable book in the world. It doesn't contain all the information, but it can point you in the right direction. It's the book I would give my 12 year old self, or pass on to my children. I've divided the book into topical chapters, and each chapter is a collection of ideas I've found important and memorable about that topic. How your mind connects the dots is part of the fun.

"The more important a decision is, the more educated you should be, the more information you should have, to make conscious decisions for yourself." – Anthony Robbins

Information is indeed powerful. Every decision you make is based on the information you've acquired in your life (your own experience and others). This book is my attempt to give you some great information, some new perspectives and avenues for exploration, and some tips to make it all more fun. I reference many books. Sometimes I list the same book as a resource for different chapters; I do this because you can read the chapters in any order and work on them individually.

After seeing excerpts from the film *The Bridge*, which shows actual footage of people committing suicide by jumping from the Golden Gate Bridge, I wanted to do something to help. There have been too many moments in my own life when I could have easily been one of those people and killed myself. Life can be cruel, unfair, and inexplicable, and it often feels like we're alone, even in the most crowded cities. No one gets through life unscarred. I have faced financial ruin, had my heart torn apart in love, been stuck in jobs I hated working far too much and sleeping far too little, been physically attacked, and seriously doubted my sanity. Often it was when I felt cockiest and most full of pride that life decided to knock me down a peg, send me back to zero, or even bury my face in the gravel.

I had to seriously ask myself: What allowed me to survive and feel that I now have a sense of inner peace and harmony? What have I found that gets me through each day?

So I made a list. This list was to be everything I considered important to survival of body, mind, and soul. I'm not using these terms lightly. I consider the contents of this book to be the informational equivalent of gold. I wish someone had given me this book when I was younger! I think of all the grief that might have been averted. But then… maybe it was those experiences I label as "bad" which made me the striving and strong person I am today. Had I not faced those demons, I might not see the value of the ideas I'm going to share with you.

Hugh Prather wrote a book called *Notes to Myself*. I lost interest while reading it but still like the title. This book is a collection of notes to myself, reminders to keep me on course. I hope you'll find something in them, too. Each section is a direction to aim your energy, to alert yourself to what you may be neglecting, to sharpen your blades. The first nine are what I call "The Essential Nine". These are things which every modern human being has to contend, and you ignore them at your peril. The rest of the book is filled with very important subject matter as well, but they can be explored as you wish, put aside for a while, and returned to when you choose. The Essential Nine will be confronting you every day of your life. I provide ideas and resources throughout the book to enter new territory.

Why is this book called *Cheat Codes for Life*? In video games, a player can often enter a "cheat code" to do things that would otherwise be impossible in the environment of the game. Things like invulnerability, super speed, and unlimited ammo are typical effects from video game cheat codes. These effects can add new dimensions to games, and make them ridiculous and fun. So too are the "cheat codes" in this book. As in a video game, employ these methods and certain results are guaranteed to follow. The "cheating" is not breaking any rules – it's

recognizing that we're the designers of this game and seeing that the rules are as flexible as we allow them to be.

HOW TO GET THE MOST FROM THIS BOOK

You could read this book from cover to cover like any book, putting it aside when you finish. You would probably get some slight benefit that way. But wouldn't you rather get a huge benefit?

This book is not like most books. It is not even like most "self-help" books – it's more like a cookbook. When you open a cookbook, there is no food. The recipes are not food, and will simply remain as words on a page until you start cooking. Sometimes you will be lazy or "not in the mood" to do the work involved in cooking – but guess what? - you can't eat words on a page (technically you can, but bleh).

So it is with this book. There are no recipes for food, but there are "recipes" to get you amazing results. Success is different for everyone and has many flavors. My hope is that by doing the work, you'll expand your palette – and come up with some unique recipes of your own.

You can also think of this book as a gateway. It is not an end in itself. Reading about an astronaut's trip to the moon is all fine and dandy, but it will never be a substitute for going to the moon. Everything worth doing must be done by YOU. Do you understand? Reading is not doing. Let me say that again: Reading is not doing. I am pointing to things, but they will not be found in this book! They will not be found in any book. Ever.

In Chip and Dan Heath's book, *Made to Stick*, they discuss an experiment involving "tapping." They had volunteers tap a song on a table (the song was "Happy Birthday") while another volunteer listened and tried to figure out what song was being tapped. The listener was able to guess what song was tapped only 2-3% of the time. Why do I mention this experiment? Because it is a good analogy for this book. I am pointing to a lot of valuable things, but if you just watch from the sidelines as a spectator, you will only hear the tapping and never get to hear the actual songs. We can talk about the music all we want, but there is no substitute for real music.

Everything must be experienced to be truly understood. Understanding is a process, not an end to be reached. Some things, moreover, are completely different from the outside. These are things that distort the very meaning of "meaning."

Things like psychedelics, meditation, language, and postmodernism, don’t even make sense from the outside.

Approach this book with an open mind. You bring different experiences and levels of awareness than anyone else. That’s fine. Some of the material will be new to you. Some will obviously be familiar, for we need reminding as much as we need educating. Whenever you think you already "know" the subjects, approach with a fresh eye. Any of the topics can be explored for a lifetime, so don’t assume you’re "finished" with something. Any two topics can be integrated, synthesized, and reevaluated. Also, look at each technique as a complete phenomenon, not a means to get something else. Doing the things I suggest to get something misses the point. They are what you get out of it, and learning to savor process is a huge chunk of life.

I can be pedantic, pompous, repetitive, contradictory, artless and humorless in this book. This information is not always presented beautifully. There are misattributed quotes and quotes without authors, and possibly garbled quotes. But there are no errors if you take the advice of the Beatles and THINK FOR YOURSELF.

Some chapters are thin because I have little to say. This does not mean those topics are unimportant. They are some of the most important things you can explore. But those chapters have to be experienced and written by you. Some chapters have a ton of resources (some have none) that you’re welcome to explore or ignore. They are not essential unless you feel they are essential.

I offer little evidence. These are my experiences.

Here’s how I suggest you work with this text:

1. First, give it a quick read through. You don’t need to linger too long on any section. There are resources and exercises throughout, but ignore them on this first read through.

2. Next, reread the Essential Nine and do some work on each of these. Read one of the suggested resources, get more organized, do an exercise I suggest. Figure out where you’re facing the greatest frustration with these Essential Nine and try approaching that topic from a new angle as suggested from the ideas I present.

3. Once you feel like the Essential Nine are working a little better, you can start exploring the other chapters in any order you like. Pick one that calls to you and explore that topic using my ideas or the resources as a springboard. You don’t need

to wait until you have the Essential Nine mastered or finished (whatever that means, anyway!). Try the sections that fascinate you most.

Overcoming internal resistance could be your biggest obstacle. Keep reading and we'll demolish this resistance.

Life is worth living. You have greatness in you. You have something to offer that no one else can. These are clichés. They're also true. Thank you for taking these steps. Let's get started.

"The big question is whether you are going to be able to say a hearty yes to your adventure." – Joseph Campbell

THE ESSENTIAL NINE

Chapter 1:

PERSONAL DEVELOPMENT AND WORLD BETTERMENT

"The greatest growth is where the greatest fear is." – Jack Canfield

Personal development, or self-help, is the basis for this book. All it means is that you realize you don't know everything (right?), that the information to make you more successful is out there, and that you're gonna make an effort to find it. Simple and rather obvious, right?

So answer me this: Why is personal development often criticized, parodied, and laughed at? Why is it that when we see someone browsing the self-help section at a bookstore we often mock that person and call them a loser? They are putting in time and effort. Isn't it strange that we live in such a cynical world that we laugh at those who attempt to improve themselves? Why should we mock those who try to find the best that the collective mind has to offer? Why don't we encourage it? Why aren't personal development and success principles taught in school from the earliest age? The resources are out there to do anything. But how often do we consciously go for what we truly want with enthusiasm and discipline? Instead we break our backs doing work we hate and buying things the world has told us will one day lead to happiness… just a little further over the horizon… you can almost see it…

But it never seems to arrive. College degrees and six-figure incomes don't seem to get us to the core of existence and what we're really after.

Personal development is different: Other people have discovered great things while exploring reality – why not find out what they did? Why not use their technologies? We may not want to climb Mt. Everest or fly to the moon or make a billion dollars – but what was going on inside those guys that allowed them to do these amazing things? What did Mother Teresa feel and know that allowed her to find peace?

We can study their work. I have made it my life to do so. I think once you experience the benefits of doing so, you will, too.

This has been my basic process for Personal Development:

1. Awareness – Become aware of what outcome you desire, and become aware of your options.

2. Choice – Choose one or more techniques or technologies to get you to your outcomes. Perhaps more importantly, figure out who you have to become to get where you want to be.

3. Take action – Act upon those choices and align with your vision.

4. Reflection/Feedback – If you achieved your outcome, reflect upon what you learned. Likewise if you did not achieve your desired outcome. Feedback can also come from peers and mentors. If you did not achieve the desired outcome, do you want to go back and try again? If so, repeat, with possibly different choices or refined techniques.

This book will help you with the first two parts of this process, awareness and choice. However, you must do parts 3 & 4! I will recommend many resources and give you many exercises, but YOU must do them, not me. Reading about other people doing exercise will not get you in shape! The Bible says, "Seek and ye shall find." If you don't seek you get zilch.

You will stumble and fall many times, and while a certain amount of dark times are inevitable in everyone's life ("the long dark tea-time of the soul", as Douglas Adams puts it), studying personal development will make darkness easier to handle, stacking the cards in your favor. Darkness, after all, is just the absence of light.

Finding this book was the first step. The next is to commit to doing whatever it takes to get your life where you want it to be. Nobody else is going to want or care to do it for you. But remember: "If you were strong enough, smart enough, and determined enough to create a comfortable lifestyle for yourself doing something you didn't like, imagine what you can create for yourself if you're doing something that you love."

Here are some key ideas I've gathered from studying the science of self-improvement:

* Over-preparation is a disease. Time spent preparing is usually better spent getting into the game. Some preparation is good, but most people prepare wayyy too much. Get out there and get your feet wet, then analyze it in your journal. But work on it every day.

* What you want also wants you. All resistance is in your head. You still have to do physical work and studying and meditating etc, but there is no conflict with the universe if you are working within your true will.

* Emergence: When you put a complex system together, and it runs, properties emerge that you could never have anticipated. Some processes guarantee results, and it's impossible to say what those results will be until you run the process, have the adventure, get the experience.

* "If you're not embarrassing yourself every day at least once you're not growing or risking or learning."

* The opposite of courage is conformity.

* "Mind operates under its own conception of itself." – A.K. Mozumdar

* "If you're not innovating you risk becoming a parody of yourself."

* "Love your mistakes. Your mistakes are your tuition to mastery."

* "Do what scares you."

* Intelligence alone will not get you everywhere in this world. We all know smart people who are overweight or lonely or miserable at their job. In fact, I would say that intelligence is far less important than willpower and self-discipline, both of which can be developed with practice and the right guides.

* Like the universe, you are here to expand.

* "If you want to be successful in life, everything you do must be an act of patricide. You must always kill the father. Every song you sing, every sentence you write, every leaf you rake must kill the father. Every act from the most august to the most banal must be patricidal if you hope to live freely and unencumbered. Even when shaving— each whisker you shave off is your father's head. And if you're using a twin blade—the first blade cuts off the father's head and as the father's neck snaps back it's cleanly lopped off by the second blade." - *My Cousin, My Gastroenterologist*, Mark Leyner

* Whatever your individual purpose in life, we are all here to bring more love into the universe.

* "Would you be hostage to the ego or host to God?" Let this question be asked you by the Holy Spirit every time you make a decision. – *A Course in Miracles*

* Whether you’re playing tennis or taking a test or going to a job interview or going on a date or fighting a war or climbing a mountain… remember… it’s all inner game. There are no opponents out there. There is no "out there".

* Four qualities you can always get better at and you can always be working on, wherever you are, whatever you’re doing: self-discipline, honesty, social skills, and organization.

* If you only do things you have mastered, you will not grow. Allowing yourself to try something new and be an amateur allows your mind to grow.

* "Nothing in the world can take the place of persistence. Talent will not; nothing is more common than unsuccessful men with talent. Genius will not; unrewarded genius is almost a proverb. Education will not; the world is full of educated derelicts. Persistence and determination are omnipotent. The slogan 'press on' has solved and always will solve the problems of the human race." – Calvin Coolidge

* Four connected items from Wikipedia:

1. Whatever the Thinker thinks, the Prover will prove. And if the Thinker thinks passionately enough, the Prover will prove the thought so conclusively that you will never talk a person out of such a belief, even if it is something as remarkable as the notion that there is a gaseous vertebrate of astronomical heft ("GOD") who will spend all eternity torturing people who do not believe in his religion. - *Prometheus Rising*, Robert Anton Wilson

2. *Confirmation bias* (or myside bias) is a tendency for people to prefer information that confirms their preconceptions or hypotheses, independently of whether they are true. People can reinforce their existing attitudes by selectively collecting new evidence, by interpreting evidence in a biased way or by selectively recalling information from memory.

3. The phrase *Law of Attraction*, used widely by New Thought writers, refers to the idea that thoughts influence chance. The Law of Attraction argues that thoughts (both conscious and unconscious) can affect things outside the head, not just through motivation, but by other means. The Law of Attraction says that which is like unto itself is drawn. Essentially, "if you really want something and truly believe it's possible, you'll get it", but putting a lot of attention and thought onto something you don't want means you'll probably get that too.

4. *The user illusion* is the illusion created for the user by a human-computer interface, for example the visual metaphor of a desktop used in many graphical

user interfaces. Some philosophers of mind have argued that consciousness is a form of user illusion. This notion is explored by Tor Nørretranders in his 1991 Danish book Mærk verden, issued in a 1998 English edition as *The User Illusion: Cutting Consciousness Down to Size*. He introduced the notion of exformation (explicitly discarded information) in this book:

According to this picture, our experience of the world is not immediate, as all sensation requires processing time. It follows that our conscious experience is less a perfect reflection of what is occurring, and more a simulation produced unconsciously by the brain. Therefore, there may exist entities beyond our peripheries, beyond what consciousness could create to isolate or reduce them.

* Don’t have goals, have dreams. Make them huge. Write them down. Pick the most important ones and take a step, even a small step, to start them today.

* You are not truly wealthy if the world is poor. You are not truly healthy if people and the planet are sick. You can only be so happy when millions of others are miserable. When you have been given much, you want to give to your friends and family. But at some point you will see that everyone is part of your family and that you have a responsibility to help this world. You have greatness inside of you and the world needs your help and love, just as much as the world wants to love and help you. And you don’t need to wait until you are rich to give something back. Volunteers are always needed – there are plenty of resources online to find volunteer opportunities.

* You don’t break habits, you replace them. You must do something every day for at least 30 to 60 days before you can even think of calling it a habit. The easiest way to do this is with a daily planner and having the self-discipline to follow your plan.

* The first ten minutes of your day are incredibly important. I wake up to gentle music (not a blaring alarm clock) at 4:45 AM. I say, "Oh yeah!" because I’m so glad to wake up and get started on my day. I laugh heartily, pray and express gratitude, do some inspirational reading, exercise, meditate and eat breakfast. I do all of these things consciously and absolutely love to do them and love the fact that I’ve built my life around the things I love. If I don’t design it, who will?

* Is the world essentially friendly or unfriendly? How you answer this question is huge.

* Anything can be done using sequential steps.

* "There is nothing either good or bad, but thinking makes it so." – *Hamlet*, William Shakespeare

* Take a class or seminar on something that would really take your life to a higher level if you got it handled.

* Start or join a book group devoted to books on personal development and world betterment. The group can all read the same book for each meeting, or each person can read a book and present a synopsis and review it for the group.

* Get a mentor for exercise, business, or something else where you could really improve your life.

* Past behavior is the best predictor of future behavior. Actions speak louder than words. But we can break the mold anytime we choose to wake up.

* Find an extra half-hour each day to improve yourself. Remove one time-waster from your life and start using the time to grow! Two common time-wasters: TV and internet!!! If you can't give them up completely, consider limiting your usage to certain days or times (for example, 20 minutes to check email in the morning and evening, and TV only on the weekends). The stricter you are about this, the more time you'll have to grow.

* Figure out a time each day when you could be listening to self-improvement audio. Whether it's in the car or when you're jogging or doing the dishes, I know you have some time each day when you could have some inspiring audio in the background. Try turning off the music and listening to some great ideas. I love music, too, but thought-provoking words from great speakers can have a much bigger effect on getting your life focused.

* Start a journal. Each day write at least five things in it you are grateful for from that day, or five successes. They don't have to be huge, but this will keep you focused on what's working and get you going in the right direction. You always have something to be grateful for. Journaling it trains your mind to always find the best.

* Make a list of (at least) 100 things you want to do in your life (e.g. see the Mona Lisa, get married, film a movie etc). Include things you want to do, have, learn, and become. They should be the things you really, really, REALLY want. Don't worry about whether you can afford it or if it's currently possible. DREAM BIG!!! This is your life and there's no reason to limit your possibilities. Then figure out from that list what you want to do this year - get started on the dreams that matter most

to you. Who knows? This could be the last year of your life. Then, what do you want to do this month? Start using a daily planner or create a list of things to accomplish each day. Do the most important things first (in the morning if you can), not the easiest things. There is magic that takes place when you write things down.

* Here are two things to do with your daily list: First, when you complete something on it, cross it out and say, "Ta da!" Then laugh (a deep belly laugh) at least six times on one breath of air. This joy you experience is an incentive to completing your goals. It's ridiculous. It works.

* Make a commitment to yourself to keep learning and exploring, to continue working on your dreams, however difficult it may seem. Make a commitment to NEVER GIVE UP.

RESOURCES

Books:

The Success Principles – Jack Canfield

The Seven Habits of Highly Effective People – Stephen Covey

The Power of Full Engagement – Jim Loehr and Tony Schwartz

Giant Steps – Anthony Robbins

The Magic of Thinking Big – David J. Schwartz

The War of Art – Steven Pressfield

50 Success Classics – Tom Butler-Bowdon

The Science of Being Great – Wallace D. Wattles

A Brief History of Everything – Ken Wilber

Start Where You Are – Chris Gardner

Prometheus Rising – Robert Anton Wilson

A Whole New Mind – Daniel Pink

The Power of Your Subconscious Mind – Joseph Murphy

The Greatest Secret in the World – Og Mandino

Life's Missing Instruction Manual – Joe Vitale

Choices – Shad Helmstetter

Brain Rules – John Medina

Audio (many of the above books and authors also have audio editions):

Les Brown – The Power of Purpose

Tony Robbins – Live with Passion

Effortless Success – Jack Canfield and Paul Scheele

If Success is a Game, These are the Rules - Cherie Carter-Scott

Audio programs by Wayne Dyer, Deepak Chopra, Ken Wilber, Bob Proctor, Michael Beckwith, Zig Ziglar, Earl Nightingale, Jim Rohn (see also my chapter on Open Source, P2P, and Peer Culture)

Chapter 2:

SPIRITUAL CONNECTION

* "If you know that ‘I’, in the sense of the person, the front, the ego, it doesn’t really exist. Then… it won’t go to your head too badly, if you wake up and discover that you’re God." – Alan Watts

* We are always connected to the Source of all being, the unifying and undivided Spirit, Infinite Intelligence, God. However, we often fall into a state of amnesia. Prayer, meditation, laughter, love, and connection to nature are a few ways to break out of this amnesia. Through regular and sustained practice of these activities we may awaken.

* You can not see God, as you can not see your own eye. You may look in a mirror and see something very like your eye, but this is not your eye. It is a reflection. And as God is Love, we see God reflected in the Love of others, and from our own eternal contact with Spirit.

* When we know that we are always walking with this immortal Spirit that loves and protects us, we can realize there is nothing to fear.

* Enlightenment has many meanings. In waking consciousness, I think of it as being in love with life and accepting its imperfections as you would a lover or dear friend. What might be perceived as "flaws" are actually quirks that make people unique and special to you. Waking enlightenment is being aware of life’s difficulties and asymmetries and loving them, seeing every inch of reality and experience as a vast field of love that is always embracing, teaching, and guiding you.

* Even when the entire world seems to be against us, this Spirit will never turn away. It moves every beat of your heart and holds the fabric of reality together.

* Stop judging and start accepting others as they are. When you judge, you close your heart. If you can’t accept others, you can’t fully accept yourself. Stop criticizing and giving advice to people who don’t ask for it, and start listening. Make yourself available to people who want your help.

* Don’t discard spirituality because of how it’s been explained to you in books, religion, or your cultural upbringing. Spirituality should be experienced firsthand, and if any instruction or practice isn’t helping you, discard it and try something else. Eventually it will start to make sense.

* Although a spiritual connection may be experienced with words, I personally experience it as a feeling, as an emotional wave and state of being.

* Pray, not to ask for what you don’t have, but to express love and gratitude for all you have been given. Use prayer to remind yourself of the perpetual connection to the Source, and to wake from the state of amnesia we often find ourselves in. I pray when I wake in the morning and before sleep at night. I also bless my food before I eat, thinking or saying, "I bless this food with love and appreciation," while placing my hands over the food and feeling love, connection. This feeling can be transmitted to anything. For example, "I bless this day with love and appreciation," "I bless this reality with love and appreciation," "I bless this trip with love and appreciation." It is a reminder that everyone plays a role in bringing God into this universe through our love.

RESOURCES

The Teachings of Don Carlos - Victor Sanchez

No Boundary – Ken Wilber

The Tao Te Ching – Lao-tse

The Upanishads

The Book – Alan Watts

A Course in Miracles – Helen Schucman

The Seven Spiritual Laws of Success – and anything by Deepak Chopra

Spiritual Liberation – Michael Beckwith

Your Sacred Self – Wayne Dyer

Chapter 3:

MOODS, EMOTIONS, AND STATES

* Cynicism is an obstacle to happiness.

* If you make eternal happiness your goal, you will fail. Sadness can’t be banished like a belligerent stepchild, nor should it be. It is a facet of the human personality as real as any "positive" emotion, and trying to remove darkness from your life will probably only cause you more grief. What you can do is prepare for sadness, learn to recognize the symptoms of its arrival, and treat it like a change in the weather, observe it, live your life and not allow it to take over, and know that it will pass.

* Positive emotions are something you do, not something that happens to you. Events do not determine your emotions, you do. The same event will affect 1000 people differently because they all have different attitudes and choose to respond differently. You are always responsible for your feelings, no one else. Outside circumstances do not dictate if you are happy or sad – you do. If you get one thing from this book, understand this concept and internalize it.

* You can use your emotions as warning lights and indicators.

* Any time you are bored, it means you are not evolving. Boredom means you aren’t pushing yourself. You are holding yourself back and not tapping your full potential. Maybe you’re afraid or never learned to push yourself. That’s okay, but if you want to grow and live the life of your dreams, you’re going to have to spread your wings and jump. The greater the potential reward, the greater risk required to get it.

* Things you perceive as "weird" have the potential to boost your intelligence and/or courage. If you can acclimatize your mind to the strange and learn to relax in that situation you will gain new vantage points and have a better understanding of the world. You will have greater empathy for others and perceive the world more richly. This does not mean you should start chopping your fingers off because that is "weird". Follow your bliss, knowing that there are plenty of unusual things out there that you will love. But you’ve got to open your eyes a little.

* "Feel the fear and do it anyway," says Susan Jeffers. When fear gets in the way of your dreams, feel the fear, acknowledge it, and say, "NO EXCUSES!! I'm not going to let fear get in the way of my happiness." Make fear a green light. When you do something you fear, you are building confidence and courage.

* When you experience fear or nervousness, give it a new name: Excitement! It's there to give you the juice to tackle whatever you face. Be grateful for it – it wakes you up.

* Your comfort zone is a prison, but the door is always open. If you wish to receive any lasting benefit from this book you must step outside your comfort zone.

* Accept that your moods will change. Never get so cocky to think you'll never fall again. Use your setbacks as learning experiences and challenges that make you a stronger person.

* The three greatest contributors to your mood: thoughts, physical factors, and your relationship to others and your environment. For many years I was tempted to say it was only my thoughts that determined how I felt. And indeed, my attitude was ultimately under my control. But your health and your environment can be a major drag if they are completely misaligned with your thoughts. For more on health, relationships and environment, see those chapters. You are responsible for all three of these contributors, but health and environment can not always be changed right away. Thoughts can always be changed NOW.

* Two ways to quickly improve your physical feelings:

1. Belly laughter. Laugh from your belly, deeply, loudly, strongly. Let it emanate from your belly and solar plexus. Put your hand there and feel it.

2. Exercise. Go for a walk, go for a run, lift weights. Any exercise is usually better than sitting there on the couch crying.

* Drugs are everywhere and have a huge impact on mood, releasing or suppressing energy. Both pharmaceutical and non-corporate (i.e. illegal) drugs should be used with caution. Even sugar, caffeine and other things we don't tend to think of as drugs will affect your mood.

* I can not do his work justice and can only point you to Ken Wilber. He has clarified so much in my understanding of states and the spectrum of consciousness. Check him out.

* Understanding most of the chapters in this book will give you a better handle on your moods and states. But it is an ever-evolving process, and also a muscle that requires daily exercise. Awareness is the first step.

* Always keep your sense of humor, always keep your cool (I like *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*'s motto, "Don't Panic!" but prefer to think in positives). Whatever you have to do, do it well, and don't let anyone take away your sense of enjoyment.

* Do you exercise every day? If not, schedule something in you can do every day, even if it's just walking (walking is a great exercise).

* Do you get sunlight every day? Get at least fifteen minutes of sun. It is essential to health and feeling good.

* Volunteer! Helping others will help you feel great. Check your library or online and find something that fits your interests. In helping others you always help yourself.

* What kind of people do you hang around with? Make a list of people you spend the most time with and be honest: Are they generally a positive, neutral, or negative influence on your mood? Weed out the negative influences as much as you can, and seek out the people who will support your visions. You are worthy of love and respect.

* Look at the music, movies, TV, websites etc you look at. How do they affect your mood? As with so many things, you have to become aware if you are to make conscious choices. Start weeding and planting different seeds. Music is a huge one. For instance, I found Radiohead to be incredibly disempowering so I stopped listening to them. Mozart, on the other hand, fills me with joy, and that's why I have it playing in the background as I write this. Stop listening to the radio or channel surfing. Make a conscious choice about what you allow into your mind. The only good censorship is self-censorship. With TV and movies, drop the drama and tragedy and go for humor. Also, watch or listen to stand up comedians. Attitudes are infectious.

* "Never complain, never explain." – (I've seen this attributed to Ernest Hemingway, Benjamin Disraeli and Katherine Hepburn)

* Learn the breathing techniques described in the Health chapter. The basic gist of good breathing is: slower, deeper, quieter, and more regular. Pay attention to your breathing and allow these alterations to occur naturally.

* When I’m low, I often feel like I don’t have any hope to get anywhere in the future. But having a plan is easy! Just whip out a piece of paper and think of some wild and crazy things you could do to get what you want. It doesn’t have to be a good plan because you know what? Plans are free. When you’re feeling better you can look at the plan you wrote down and maybe it will be gold and maybe it will be garbage. If it’s garbage throw it where garbage belongs and make a new plan. But it might be gold or have an inkling of gold in it. Maybe it just needs revision. The point is, plans get us excited about the future and point us in a direction. We can always change that direction later. My dreams are slow to change, but my plans to get there get revised whenever necessary. (Also, don’t confuse having a plan with over preparing – any good plan has you taking action today)

* Take a few minutes each day to cultivate the emotions most important to you. Recognize that you are the one creating the emotions. Keep a list of these valuable emotions with you and cultivate their experience whenever you have free time, or set aside time each day. The emotions I’ve found most helpful to cultivate: joy/bliss, gratitude, love for everyone, everything, and every experience, a humorous viewpoint, awe and reverence for every moment of your life. Turn the switch on and less pleasant emotions have no room to grow.

* Whenever you hurt yourself or spill something or something goes wrong, learn to laugh. This may not always be appropriate, but when you stub your toe and it starts to hurt, you can actually condition your brain to release endorphins and feel less pain by laughing. Just force out a deep belly laugh for as long as you can. If you drop, spill, or break something, don’t say "FUCK!!!!" and get angry. Just laugh, and remember that you always get to decide how you feel. And having that control is worth laughing about. View mistakes as "reminders" to laugh.

* "Seize the moments of happiness, love and be loved! That is the only reality in the world, all else is folly. It is the one thing we are interested in here." – *War and Peace*, Leo Tolstoy

RESOURCES

Happy for No Reason – Marci Shimoff

Feel the Fear… and Do It Anyway – Susan Jeffers

The Power of Positive Thinking – Norman Vincent Peale

177 Mental Toughness Secrets of the World Class – Steve Siebold

The Geography of Bliss – Eric Weiner

You Can Be Happy No Matter What – Richard Carlson and Wayne Dyer

Emotional Intelligence – Daniel Goleman

Chicken Soup for the Soul – Jack Canfield and Mark Victor Hansen

Little Gold Book of YES! Attitude – Jeffrey Gitomer

Stoned Free – Patrick Wells and Douglas Rushkoff

Get High Now (Without Drugs) – James Nestor

The Mastery of Love – Don Miguel Ruiz

Chapter 4:

HEALTH

* "The soul is the same in all living creatures, although the body of each is different." – Hippocrates

* Like happiness, health is a choice. It is interwoven with our being, our friends, lifestyle, work, and environment. It is inseparable from our mood and ability to succeed.

* You cannot rely on doctors alone to keep you healthy. You are the person primarily responsible for your health, understanding your specific body, and for researching its peculiarities.

* I may have food that is right for me, air that is clean, and pure water, but if I engage in work I loathe and surround myself with negative people, stress will accumulate.

* Get a good water filter and make water, tea (preferably without caffeine), and natural juice your primary liquids.

* Have plants throughout your house.

* "He who has health has hope; and he who has hope has everything." – Arabic proverb

* Michael Pollan's advice from *In Defense of Food*: "Eat food. Not too much. Mostly plants." Processed "food" doesn't qualify in his definition.

* "Of all the forms of inequality, injustice in health care is the most shocking and inhumane." – Rev. Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr.

* Everyone needs to release stress, preferably at least once or twice a day. Exercise is often cited as a form of stress release, but most exercise is not rejuvenating the way meditation, yoga, tai chi and other bodywork with an inward component are. Harnessing chi (or ki, prana etc), working with the vital force of breath, and altering brainwaves have a much deeper effect than simply exercising.

* Find harmony between the adventure of chaos and the security of order. Find comfort in the right people and the right place. Accept death and love life. Be in the moment and don’t obsess over the past and future.

* Eat food you love, food that loves you. I like starchy foods and try to keep it fresh, organic, with little or no processing. I’m generally (but not strictly) vegetarian. I rarely eat salad or steak – not because they are "healthy" or "unhealthy" but because my body does not like them. Nobody knows your body as well as you. Doctors may know things about "general" bodies, but you are master of your own ship. Choose food that you love, food that supports you.

* The body is constructed for movement, not sitting hours at a time.

* Walk more. You may, of course, add a more formal style of exercise to your lifestyle, but walking regularly as a natural structure in your day will take care of many health problems. It doesn’t require equipment and can be done anywhere. I advocate walking slowly. Don’t even think about putting the next step forward. Just let your arms swing loosely and coast along for at least half an hour. By walking slowly for long periods of time, your baseline metabolism will increase.

* Find exercise or sports that you love to do, something you will long to do when you’ve been sitting down for too long. Exercise doesn’t need to be a chore, and with so many options, why should it be? Try skiing, snorkeling, dancing, juggling… the list is endless. They will open up your world and be their own reward. But guess what? On top of all that fun you’ll be getting stronger, faster, better.

* Four areas of exercise to include in whatever activities you take up:

1. Aerobic: Exercise that improves the body’s use of oxygen (e.g. cycling, swimming, jumping rope).

2. Strength: Building bone, muscle, tendon, and ligament strength (e.g. weight training, resistance training, isometrics).

3. Flexibility: Increasing the body’s ability to stretch (stretching).

4. Balance and Coordination: Activities that emphasize bodily coordination and maintaining a sense of balance (e.g. dancing, cycling, gymnastics).

* Prevention is easier than curing.

* Take care of your teeth!! See a dentist twice a year… the longer you wait the greater your chance of tooth decay or gum disease. Brush at least twice a day, floss daily, and don't take your teeth for granted! Keep your tongue clean as well. Find a dentist using modern techniques and technologies, who listens and responds to your concerns.

* We are part of the world and our health is connected with the Earth. We can't be truly healthy until the world is restored, the air and water clean, and natural beauty reconstitutes urban miasma. Watching a sunset, walking through a forest, and generally communing with nature restores our souls and reminds us what we are, underneath the masks and uniforms. Connecting with the Earth is as important as connecting with others. Only by going away can we return to the human community.

* The mind, body, and soul must feel connected to love for health to prosper. Love of self is sparked by love of others and connection to purpose. Having "health" and not loving others is like having money that you can't spend: useless.

* Your body needs sleep! Figure out the right amount for you. When I exercise I need less sleep, but I still meditate and rest throughout the day. I get up at 4:45 AM most mornings but to do that I usually go to sleep by 10. Insomnia is very rare and I'm usually passed out within 5 minutes.

* Don't depend on vitamins to supply all your nutritional needs. They are called supplements for a reason! I do recommend a general multivitamin, though, to prevent deficiencies in the common diet. Vitamin D is especially important in winter months, and for those who don't eat seafood (I avoid it because the oceans are filled with mercury and ocean borne contaminants), an Omega-3 fatty acid supplement is extremely important. Omega-3 fatty acids have been linked to cardiovascular and brain health, and seem to be connected with reduced risk of certain types of cancer. The benefits of taking a multivitamin and Omega-3 supplement daily can be enormous. Not just in quality of life 30 or 40 years down the line, but today! Being healthy is something you get to enjoy right now.

* I've also found a light melatonin supplement helpful once or twice a week.

* You have no doubt heard of the health benefits of other foods such as red wine, dark chocolate, and green tea. A varied diet is important, so try inserting some of these in periodically. Make vegetables, fruits, whole grains, and beans the cornerstone of your diet.

* Avoid fads (and oh don't we love diet fads) and focus on being fit, strong, flexible, with a good sense of coordination and endurance.

* Natural lighting is usually better for both the eyes and the mood.

* I've removed moles on my body with products containing bloodroot. It is painless, easy, cheap and leaves less of a scar than the scalpel and stitch method used by most doctors. Why don't doctors use this? Habit, the "system", ignorance? Mole removal is obviously not the only "alternative" cure out there, and it's worth exploring alternate paradigms before putting your life in the hands of someone who may not be completely informed himself. We are reaching the point where anyone can learn as much about a medical condition as a doctor by a simple google search. This isn't to say we should drop doctors completely. Andrew Weil presents some broadminded ideas in *Why Our Health Matters*.

* Vision has long fascinated me. I found books by William Bates and Aldous Huxley on natural ways to improve eyesight as a teenager and went on to find more recent books like *Seeing Without Glasses*. My vision is not 20/20 because I spend so much time reading and on the computer, but when I practice drawing and travel (i.e. don't read so much) I notice slight increases in my vision. One of my favorite practices is to look at the sun (early or late in the day, not at midday) through my closed eyes and allow the red to relax my eyes as much as possible. There are numerous other vision exercises, but I find this one the most refreshing.

* As with anything in life, you will benefit most from health practices when you go beyond the expectations of society and hold yourself accountable to your own higher standard. There is no advantage to being average.

* "Health and cheerfulness naturally beget each other." – Joseph Addison

* Honestly ask yourself: Are you generally happy with your life? Do you feel loved and have the opportunities to express love? Do you like the people you spend the most time with? Do you go outside your comfort zone regularly? Does your life have a sense of adventure? Do you have areas of emotional, physical, and logical security you can go to when you need to rest? Do you live in the present and not obsess about the past and future? Do you accept your eventual death and live each day to the fullest? Sure, there are always ways to improve your life situation, but being happy with your reality is a vital piece of the health puzzle. By connecting mind, body, and spirit to love, health thrives.

* Learn to juggle. It's a great way to maintain your reflexes and coordination, and once you learn it you'll have the basic skill forever (like riding a bike). It also teaches you to relax under pressure.

* Is there anywhere you can walk to instead of driving? Is a car always your first means of travel? Some people always leave their house through the garage, because the automobile is ingrained in their existence. Try thinking outside the box and figure out where you can walk or ride a bike to instead of driving.

* Throw out food that you know is not doing you any good. Take a look through your cupboard and fridge and GET RID OF IT. Give it to charity or throw it out, and stop buying it. Getting it away from you removes one more level of resistance.

* Take a healthy cooking class if you really have trouble preparing healthy food. You can't simply eradicate the negative – you must replace it with the positive.

* Try eating three meals a day. Put the food on your plate and don't nibble or snack until you're ready to begin. When you finish the food on your plate, eat no more. If you find you just can't go without snacking and need more after eating a full meal, have a light fruit or vegetables at the ready (apples, carrots, celery etc). Only allow yourself to snack on light fruit and vegetables.

* Enroll in some kind of health-related course. It could be a more traditional information class, or exercise, or an alternate health practice. Doing things as a group makes it easier and you're accountable to a class or instructor.

* Try weight lifting or some other form of strength training. There are benefits that aerobic exercise simply doesn't provide, and you'll notice them with as little as three 15 minutes sessions a week.

* Close your eyes and imagine how you will look, act, and feel at age 100. Whatever you saw, close your eyes again and imagine yourself at age 100 doing more than you're even doing now, being alert, healthy, and happy. How you envision your future will program your subconscious to get you there. Anytime you think of frailty or disease when you are old, take a few moments to visualize how healthy and beautiful you'll be at age 100 (or 200 or 300… who knows how long we will live in the future?).

RESOURCES

Most of Andrew Weil's books are great starting points for exploring health. I also really enjoyed his audio programs *Breathing: The Master Key to Self-Healing*, *Self-Healing With Sound and Music*, and *Heal Yourself With Medical Hypnosis*.

Perfect Health – Deepak Chopra

Juggling for the Complete Klutz – John Cassidy and B.C. Rimbeaux

Chapter 5:

RELATIONSHIPS AND COMMUNITY

* "No man is an island, entire of itself; every man is a piece of the continent, a part of the main; if a clod be washed away by the sea, Europe is the less, as well as if a promontory were, as well as if a manor of thy friends or of thine own were; any man's death diminishes me, because I am involved in mankind; and therefore never send to know for whom the bell tolls; it tolls for thee." – John Donne

* Few things can give you better perspective on the important people in your life than being taken away from them for a while. Try traveling alone in a country where you don't speak the language and you will realize how even strangers you can barely communicate with are a gift.

* Acknowledge the people you have in your life right now. Even the ones who irritate you. Don't wait until you lose them to let them know you love them.

* Don't let the rude behavior of others control how you act. Always have manners. Rudeness is a cry for help. Try to help and if there's resistance, keep your distance until the other person's mood changes.

* People have everything we want.

* Hug more. You can never hug enough. Hugs keep you healthy and happy, connect you to others, and act as a safety net for moods.

* Many of us are born in places and communities where we don't fit in. Traveling allows us to see other cultures and other ways of being. "Find the others," said Timothy Leary.

* I don't use the phrase "the masses." It's a point of view I don't participate in.

* The potential for good and beauty is in every place, every person.

* Raising children is something I haven't had the chance to experience yet. But I have been a teacher and preschool sub and also worked with students for many years in dormitories and school programs. These experiences are some of my most

cherished memories, and I think the responsibility to help children and others who need care is one of the great joys in life.

* Then came Peter to him, and said, "Lord, how oft shall my brother sin against me, and I forgive him? till seven times?"

Jesus saith unto him, "I say not unto thee, Until seven times: but, Until seventy times seven." – Matthew 18:21-22

* Forgive others in your heart if you can't speak or write your forgiveness. You forgive to help yourself.

* Neil Strauss popularized the idea of pickup artists and seduction (one of the most successful marketing campaigns of the last ten years, along with *The Secret* and Eckhart Tolle's books) in his book *The Game*. And while much of the ideas from that community have validity and have aided my understanding of the male/female dynamic, I also see a lot of posturing and inauthentic behavior emerging as a result. Too many people are running their lives on the programs of others, overcompensating, living as social robots, and not allowing their true self to come through. I've found it far more valuable to be myself (the most confident and effervescent me possible) than any routines practiced in bars and nightclubs night after night. I don't like bars. I don't like nightclubs. So why should I spend hours in them trying to find a girl who probably isn't what I'm even after? There are plenty of girls for me in other places where I'd rather be. I encourage you to accept yourself as you are, to bring out your best, and do it loudly. Someone will take notice if you keep looking and they will love you as you are.

* We do not say 'God has love" or "God gives love." We say "God is love."

* Bring more love into this world. Make it a better place. Be nice. It really is that simple.

* Think of yourself as a leader in your community. Don't complain. Either do your part to make it better or find a different community.

* Participate in a Free Hugs Day (the Free Hugs campaign has people holding a "free hugs" sign in a public place and hugging any stranger who wants a hug)!

* Offer your couch (or extra room) on couchsurfing.org (or a similar site). I suggest you only have guests who have positive references, but opening your home (and heart) is like magically manifesting instant friends.

* Offer to host a party/picnic/barbecue/potluck for your class, work, or any group you're involved with. Quit waiting to be invited and start taking the initiative.

RESOURCES

Social Intelligence – Daniel Goleman

King, Warrior, Magician, Lover - Robert Moore and Douglas Gillette

The Power of Nice – Linda Kaplan Thaler and Robin Koval

Chapter 6:

ENVIRONMENT AND SENSE OF PLACE

* Our environment is our second skin, the outer layer of our brain, the muzak always running through our life. It makes us, controls us, talks to us, and breathes through us. We are the expression of our environment just as it is an expression of us.

* A few years ago I was staying in a hostel in San Francisco, one of my favorite cities, and I met a guy visiting from New York City. He hated San Francisco. It was too small. Too pokey. Not a real city at all. The very things I love about it were a major turn-off for him.

"You need to be zen about it," I said. "It shouldn't matter where you're at. It's the same you everywhere."

"That's a little true," he said. "But I'm not the Buddha. I'm just this guy, and there are places a person belongs and places he doesn't."

We agreed to leave it at that. As the years passed I traveled more and eventually found myself living in Seattle for a year. I hated it.

Although I still think that travel is impossible, that everywhere is the same place and that everything is happening in one instant, one dot of dimensionless space that is not space… I do now see that guy's point. Just as certain people will fit you better than others, so too will various places. There are so many variables: sensory variations, communication styles, climate etc. Preferences will always exist.

The remarkable thing is that we can't see these variables as variables until we go to other places. Linger in a place and it becomes your default thinking style and casts your old environments in a new light. The new place might make us louder or smoother or more abrasive or introverted. It will not have the same effect on two people and there are people who will always hate San Francisco and those who wouldn't choose to live anywhere but Seattle.

You wouldn't force yourself to listen to music you don't like, would you? So why would you live somewhere you don't like? I'm willing to bet there's a place out there you will LOVE, so why not find it?

* Travel can be easy and cheap. The more you do it (as with anything), the more tricks you'll learn to make the "impossible" possible. Study abroad, go on family trips, school trips, church trips, teach abroad, join the Peace Corps. If you really want it, you can make it happen.

* New environments allow you to put on new masks and realize new potentials in your personality. What you think of as your personality is largely a habitual response to your environment.

* Never before in human history has it been easier to live in other places and visit other continents. Expand your comfort zone and travel anywhere that's reasonably safe. Play with your environments. Whatever you have to leave behind wasn't really a part of you after all. The only constant is what's inside your head and even that's going to change. Connection with others is more important than any single location. "Home is where the heart is."

* When I first went to Hawaii my mind felt so calm and I realized there were no billboard advertisements. What a wonderful idea. So much in the environment is available for editing.

* Imagine how much more beautiful, quiet, and safe the world would be without cars.

* You have control of your home, your workplace, your city, your country. You have the ability to add changes or move elsewhere. If you don't like the color of your walls, paint them. If you want cleaner air in your city, then work with the necessary organizations to bring that change about. Any change you are clear about can be brought about.

* A home without plants is dead.

* I imagine better soundproofing in homes, not using denser building materials, but with fields that electronically shield sounds. I do not have the know-how to construct these, but the idea is out there and has trillions of dollars in potential profit.

* I imagine a public transportation system that mixes buses with taxis. Using a cell phone or other handheld device, you enter your destination and it's relayed with your location to a computer that figures out the closest bus-taxi and passengers with similar destinations. The bus-taxi uses GPS to locate you and pick you up. I think this could be cheaper and more efficient that buses or taxis.

* "The law is an ass." – Charles Dickens

* Even within the U.S., laws regarding drugs, sexuality, and gambling vary from state to state. When you cross international borders things change even more dramatically. Amsterdam is not Tokyo.

* I think the world is going to go through massive changes in the next few years as robotics, virtual reality, augmented reality, nanotechnology, and computer sciences are ramped up. And there will always be unanticipated changes. I don't think we can rely on random forces to save us, but I do believe that artificial intelligence and robots will help us salvage the planet in ways we can't imagine. Landfills will be the new gold mines and websites will replace governments.

* I've often found it necessary to alternate between a stable environment that fosters my health and productivity, and chaotic traveling, that helps me connect socially and explode creatively. Your environmental needs change throughout life.

* A good environment promotes bliss and inspiration. Some factors to consider: city vs. country vs. suburbs, climate, population density, environmental niche, transportation, lighting, colors, sound, humidity, nearness to bodies of water (especially the ocean), social customs, languages used, friendliness, group dynamics, level of homogeneity, housing styles… and anything else that you find relevant. You know your own interests and comforts better than me.

Chapter 7:

MEDIA/FRAMES

* "Survival is not possible if one approaches his environment, the social drama, with a fixed, unchangeable point of view – the witless repetitive response to the unperceived." – Marshall McLuhan

* Every media form has an active and passive component. My purpose is to encourage the active role. Don't just watch plays - ACT! Don't just listen to music – PLAY MUSIC! Be a producer, not a consumer.

* The media we use is the glass we hold up to the world, the frame, the narrative shell wherein we find that elusive thing called meaning.

* "He stood still in the gloom of the hall, trying to catch the air that the voice was singing and gazing up at his wife. There was grace and mystery in her attitude as if she were a symbol of something. He asked himself what is a woman standing on the stairs in the shadow, listening to distant music, a symbol of." – "The Dead", James Joyce

* One reason I like James Joyce (especially *Ulysses*) is the way his writing fosters an awareness of the media-saturated environment we live in. Each chapter of *Ulysses* has a different style, a different way of thinking and interpreting the world, each as valid and limited as the others.

* Cities are immersion tanks for media and people who live in them all their life are often unaware of this.

* Media synchronizes brains.

* Choice! Wake up! Do you not understand how much is under your control? But you must become aware, you must choose. If you don't choose your media it will be foisted upon you, shoved down your throat.

* Extend this quote beyond newspapers:

"To read a newspaper is to refrain from reading something worth while. The natural laziness of the mind tempts one to eschew authors who demand a

continuous effort of intelligence. The first discipline of education must therefore be to refuse resolutely to feed the mind with canned chatter. People tell me that they must read the papers so as to know what is going on. In the first place, they could hardly find a worse guide. Most of what is printed turns out to be false, sooner or later. Even when there is no deliberate deception, the account must, from the nature of the case, be presented without adequate reflection and must seem to possess an importance which time shows to be absurdly exaggerated; or vice versa. No event can be fairly judged without background and perspective." – Aleister Crowley

* An ubiquitous media texture creates uniformity.

* Media preferences and saturation levels vary with each individual and with that individual's mood and experience.

* You can be a dilettante in any media form, but if you want to gain any level of mastery you must practice and produce regularly.

* "Media" encompasses any form of communication. In its broadest sense this can include things like drugs, architecture, disease, sex, weather, clothes, and sports.

* Every experience has a unique texture. These textures cannot be replicated, but simulated approximations of these textures can be created for transmission to others. We call these simulations media.

* McLuhan said that the medium of communication is infinitely more important than the content of that medium. "The medium is the message," was his original catchphrase, but I like how he morphed it later into "The medium is the massage."

* When we share an experience, we become a little more alike.

* We become accustomed (or addicted) to our media, and changing media forms can seem painful. This is why a round-the-world trip can be so worthwhile. It forces you through hundreds of media microworlds, cultures that force your brain to stretch and grow. Birth has varying degrees of discomfort.

* Picasso made us see the visual world anew; Joyce did the same with our inner world. William Burroughs was my own personal eye-opener. Trying to define or explain Burroughs away is insufficient. His texts mean something different to everyone. I recommend The Job. He is a writer's writer and the best way to understand things like the cut-up and fold-in methods is to practice them yourself.

His influence eventually extended beyond text into video and music, and I see his work as a critical splinter in the cognitive history of the world.

* Jerry Mander's *Four Arguments for the Elimination of Television* also had a huge effect on me. The details of his arguments have slightly changed as television has evolved, but the book affected me enough to eliminate the television set from my home. I still see the occasional film, but as with music, TV has become a default filler of brainspace. If you want the ability to turn off your inner dialogue, give the TV a break. It will affect your perception of time and "literally" (what does it mean when the word literally is in quotes?) blow your mind.

* McLuhan also said that media is an extension of our nervous system, bringing you information from around the world. It is not your experience, though. You are taking in media right now with these words, but these words may as well just be blotches on a white background until you go out and explore these things yourself.

* The *Sorrows of Young Werther*, Goethe's Romantic look at unrequited love and suicide, caused an outbreak of suicides in Europe when it was released. A culture was created, just as rap music allowed for new verbal possibilities but also created a culture of anger and demeaning others. Every culture has its limitations.

* By alternating between media cultures and going on media fasts, the limits of any culture can be transcended.

* McLuhan: "For the 'message' of any medium or technology is the change of scale or pace or pattern that it introduces into human affairs."

* I genuinely believe that a lot of things are much better today than at any time in history. But part of the effect of media following us more and more is that we notice the problem areas more and more. There are fewer wars today than twenty years ago, but we are constantly barraged by news of war. Being informed is one thing. Being inundated is ridiculous.

* Which of your senses are you neglecting? Just as you can limit certain media, you can give attention to each of your senses. For instance, spend a week doing something for your sense of touch each day: get a massage, do acupuncture, walk barefoot on grass, pet a cat, go swimming, etc. Then the next week do something each day specific to smell, and so on. Consciously explore the different modalities of communication and you'll see you're probably neglecting at least one.

* Marketing and business models encourage media habits. Cable/internet contracts, ipods, compulsive email checking, Netflix, phones we always have with us – these are but a few examples of the parasitic nature of media.

* Genre is an experiential niche reiterated through time.

* I use Adblock Plus – an advertising filter for my Firefox browser. On a recent upgrade there was a glitch and it stopped working for a while. I became aware again of how saturated with ads the internet is. It was really quite shocking. If you browse the internet, get an adblocking program. If you watch TV, use DVDs or Tivo. There are enough advertisements in the content itself, and there's no need to suffer through any more.

* When I lived in South Korea I went hiking and all the trails were plotted out with stones, meticulously engineered. I couldn't believe how unnatural nature had become. Humanity's influence is everywhere, however "natural" we might fool ourselves into believing otherwise. Media is the air quality, the jets passing miles overhead, the clothes you wear into the forest, the food you eat.

* Depending on your definitions, the internet could be a new medium, or just a collage of old media. The effects of the internet are new because it acts as an accelerator for so many other media. It is constantly alternating between forms, between passivity and interactivity, and evolving faster than any other medium in human history. The collage style of the internet brings cultures and ideas together in a way that newspapers or magazines will never do. There is more international bleedover, and empathy and mental flexibility are required to reach understanding.

* Do media bring us together? Or do they create padding between people, pushing us further and further apart, away from genuine contact and presence? Maybe it can do both, and like anything, has the potential for abuse.

* To the undifferentiated One, the spirit of which we're all connected, this universe is one great glob of media that allow It to see Itself. We are born into being and there is no Nature vs. Nurture. Even your DNA is a form cast on the infinite. Even our bodies are media that the supreme identity gets to experience and try on for a while.

* I'd like students to use and CREATE with every media form available. Let's turn up the output and transition from passivity to activity.

* "Communication must become total and conscious before we can stop it." – William Burroughs

RESOURCES

Marshall McLuhan is the godfather of media studies. His most famous work is *Understanding Media*, but my favorite book he did (with Quentin Fiore) is *The Medium is the Massage*, a sort of comic book on media effects.

Four Arguments for the Elimination of Television – Jerry Mander

Everything Bad is Good For You – Steven Johnson

Coercion – Douglas Rushkoff

The Teachings of Don Carlos – Victor Sanchez

Chapter 8:

WORK

* "Follow your bliss." – Joseph Campbell

* A common image that persists in the blingy IMAX lifestyle of the 2000s is that of a "successful person": It usually involves someone lying on a tropical beach in a Hawaiian t-shirt, sunglasses draped across his or her face, cocktail on the lounge chair, sunburning flesh as the tide rolls in, and a temptation to doze off for a few more hours. As enjoyable as that may sound if you're working a job you hate, lying on that beach forever would be downright boring… as are most passive activities used to define lifestyle.

* Work can be your most consistent joy. Can you even conceive of that possibility?

* Wealth is nice to have, since it frees your time and energy for better things, but if you don't make decisions about what those "better things" are to do with your time, no one will make those choices for you.

* Work is the reason you're here. It is your mission, your calling. It is what gives you energy and drives you insane with joy. It may or may not be how you make money. In fact, working may be the most inefficient way to make money.

* When you really, really want something, you GO FOR IT. When you don't care about it, you will only put in a halfhearted attempt at best. If I am fulfilling my life purpose and following my dreams, I put my back into it and the universe is more likely to give me a helping hand.

* "How in the hell could a man enjoy being awakened at 6:30 a.m. by an alarm clock, leap out of bed, dress, force-feed, shit, piss, brush teeth and hair, and fight traffic to get to a place where essentially you made lots of money for somebody else and were asked to be grateful for the opportunity to do so?" – Charles Bukowski

* What would you do if you had a trillion dollars in the bank? "Oh, I'd be on a beach doing nothing," you say. Perhaps. For about a week, or a month, or even a year. But eventually that would bore you senseless and you would want to do something with your life. Really give it some thought. If money wasn't an issue,

what would you be doing with your life? That’s the kind of work you should be doing. It may be many things, and you may have to play around with it and your life to see how you can live an abundant lifestyle doing the work you love. But there is a way if you are willing to look for it. Yes, you probably have responsibilities and people and things to take care of. But don’t forget your responsibility to yourself. Commit to doing the work you love for at least an hour every day, even if you aren’t getting paid for it.

* Are you fully using the unique talents with which you have been endowed? You may have to do several types of work to do this.

* "This is the true joy in life, the being used for a purpose recognized by yourself as a mighty one; the being a force of nature instead of a feverish, selfish little clod of ailments and grievances complaining that the world will not devote itself to making you happy.

I am of the opinion that my life belongs to the whole community, and as long as I live it is my privilege to do for it whatever I can.

I want to be thoroughly used up when I die, for the harder I work the more I live. I rejoice in life for its own sake. Life is no "brief candle" for me. It is a sort of splendid torch which I have got hold of for the moment, and I want to make it burn as brightly as possible before handing it on to future generations." - George Bernard Shaw

* You know you’re in the right field when you care about being in the top 10% of people doing that work. Personally, I don’t want to be in the top 10% - I want to be the best. When I write a story or make a comic I feel like I’m breaking new ground and doing great things no one else has ever done in all of human history. That’s how I know I’m doing the right work for me, right now. How about you?

* "Work and play are words used to describe the same thing under differing conditions." – Mark Twain

* A lot of people love their job. They wake up in the morning eager to get to it and they work late into the night. Osamu Tezuka produced 50,000 pages of comics in his life. That doesn’t happen by accident. Have you ever considered getting paid to do what you love? Lots of people do – why not you? Make a list of ten or twenty things you absolutely love to do, things that bring you the most joy, times in your life when you’ve been most happy. Then brainstorm each of those things and come up with five ways you can make money doing each of those things. You’ll have at least 50 potential professions you can start looking into.

* "Plough deep while sluggards sleep." - Benjamin Franklin

* When you've decided where you want to devote your energy, make it your hobby. You only have so much energy. Spending it in front of the TV or surfing the internet aimlessly is not helping you – it's giving your power to others! Make your hobbies active and supportive of your goals. If it isn't supporting your life purpose and dreams, then consider scrapping it. You may only get one chance for an opportunity that will open up worlds to you. When the time comes, be ready. Find a mentor, ask the right questions, read books and "plough deep" as Franklin put it. Most people can be at the top of their field in just a few years if they put in the time.

* Use the best tools. If there's some tool you wish you had, you are losing money and limiting your reach until you get that tool.

* "Blessed is he who has found his work; let him ask no other blessedness." – Thomas Carlyle

* Do work that allows you to put all your might into it.

* When you're at the highest skill level you will be rewarded. Keep experimenting and put yourself out there and you will find support. Beyond money, you will find greater rewards: impact and personal satisfaction.

* Here are some considerations in determining your work satisfaction. Figure out which ones matter most to you:

1. People - Do you like the people you work closest with? Do they inspire, support, and challenge you? Do you consider them intelligent? Do they share key values with you? Do you connect emotionally? Do you work with too many people? Too few?

2. Company/Organization Mission – Is your work in line with your mission and values? How much do you care about your work? Do you care so passionately about it that you will put 100% into it?

3. Job Malleability - Can you alter your job? How much control over it do you have? Can you tweak it as you change and the world changes?

4. Physical Convenience - How convenient are the logistics of the job? Do you have a long or short commute? Is it comfortable to get to work? Does it pay well?

Does it have the benefits you want? Is the environment you work in comfortable (e.g. city vs. country, office vs. outdoors vs. work from home, etc)?

5. Pace of the Work Environment - Are the energy level, deadlines, urgency, and general pace of your environment (company, organization) right for you? Is it too fast? Too slow? Does your job challenge you?

6. Scrutiny – Who will review the quality of your work and how often? Your boss? Co-workers? The public (physically or through market forces)? What standards will you be held to? What profitability standards? If self-employed, how often will you review your own work? How often will you seek others (accountants, mentors etc) for feedback? How much of your feedback will be self-feedback? Is this the level of scrutiny you want?

* "If a man has a talent and cannot use it, he has failed. If he has a talent and uses only half of it, he has partly failed. If he has a talent and learns somehow to use the whole of it, he has gloriously succeeded, and won a satisfaction and a triumph few men ever know." – Thomas Wolfe

RESOURCES

If you answer the questions in this chapter honestly, you probably won't need many resources. You'll just need the courage to make some small or big changes in your work. Here is one book on work that I wish every high school student would read:

The Adventures of Johnny Bunko – Daniel H. Pink and Rob Ten Pas

Chapter 9:

FINANCE, INVESTING, AND WEALTH

* Understanding money may sound drab compared to the lofty ideals of the other chapters, but money is an important form of energy at this point in time on Earth. Overlook it at your peril. If you don't have it handled it will weigh down your other efforts. If you're a young person, getting a handle on money will "pay off" even more the sooner you do it. I wish I had saved more of the birthday cash I got as a kid. I wish I had opened an IRA and put some money in it from my very first job at 17. As it is, I didn't start taking responsibility for my investing choices till I was 25 – and even this is a relatively young age for most people who want to blow every paycheck and hope it all works out down the line… somehow. Don't get me wrong, garbage frivolities have their time and place, but to build your lifestyle around them is a path to failure.

* "Achieving financial security is an excellent exercise in creative imagination." – Earl Nightingale

* Get over the idea that rich people are bad and that money is evil. Money allows you a level of freedom that scarcity does not.

* There are basically two mindsets you can have about money: love & abundance, or fear & scarcity. I'd say about 99% of people are in the fear and scarcity category.

* People rarely get rich trading their time for money. A more common way to get rich is to sell a product or service, preferably one that doesn't require you to be present once it's been created.

* Think multiple streams of passive income.

* I don't claim to have totally mastered my finances. I do claim that if you take an active role in handling your money you will fare better than if you rely solely on society's mechanisms.

* "The most powerful force in the universe is compound interest." – Albert Einstein (apocryphal, but a good quote)

* As with many things, investing can appear complicated till you get your feet wet. Getting started will always look like the hardest part. Just do it! Start with a little each week. If your work has a 401K, put it there. If not, open an IRA. You can do a simple savings account IRA or stocks or mutual funds. There are tons of books out there to help you decide, but I recommend starting with a savings account IRA. You can always open other IRAs, and the great thing about a savings account IRA is that there are no maintenance fees (through ingdirect.com, for example) and there's no risk. You know that your money is always going to go up. It may be a small interest rate, but it should beat inflation and compound. Another great thing about modern investing is that you don't need a broker anymore – the internet keeps killing the middleman.

* Remember that money is not your most important form of energy. Take a look at Napoleon Hill's list of the *12 Things That Constitute Real Riches*:

1. A Positive Mental Attitude

2. Sound Physical Health

3. Harmony in Human Relations

4. Freedom From Fear

5. The Hope of Future Achievement

6. The Capacity for Applied Faith

7. Willingness to Share One's Blessings with Others

8. To Be Engaged in a Labor of Love

9. An Open Mind on All Subjects Toward All People

10. Complete Self-Discipline

11. Wisdom with Which to Understand People

12. Financial Security

Notice how money is at the end of the list.

* It's funny. Many people think that money is the only kind of wealth. But would you give up your friends and family for a million dollars? How much money would you sell your arms or legs for? I mean no disrespect to the handicapped

since they too have opportunities and gifts that others may lack, but I don't think most people would willfully part with the real riches they do have. Money comes and goes. True wealth is independent of financial markets.

* Why do so many people plan their lives around money? Many of us devote years or even decades of life fulfilling someone else's dream because it will supposedly make money. But what is the price tag for sacrificing your happiness? What is the cost of giving up inner fulfillment? Keep your dreams.

* Receiving unearned money is fraught with peril. Winning the lottery might better be viewed as a curse than a blessing. Its disruptive effect on families is notorious. Inherited money has a similar effect, as does unearned money in general. Gandhi went so far as to include it in his list of "Seven Social Sins": politics without principles, wealth without work, pleasure without conscience, knowledge without character, commerce without morality, science without humanity, and worship without sacrifice.

* Having a lot of money will not make you happy. It will make you more of what you already are. If you are a bitter, angry person then it will make you even nastier. If you're a happy and loving person, it will allow you to be happier and even more loving. Wealth allows you to use your other abilities more effectively.

* As with anything else, take responsibility for your money and investments.

* Diversify with varying levels of risk. Never put all your eggs in one basket.

* Avoid frivolous debt. I'm tempted to say, "Avoid ALL debt," but there are justifiable reasons for debt. If you have debt, especially that monster of monsters, credit card debt, figure out how you can consolidate it and put it behind you as soon as possible. And once it's gone, avoid it like the plague. Melt your credit cards to wax if you must.

* Have clear financial goals.

* Add value to this world and you will be rewarded. Create a valuable product or service. A jet pack. Electronic sound barriers. Impossible ideas that might be constrained by current technology… but perhaps not, or at least not for long. Dream big and WRITE YOUR IDEAS DOWN. If you keep a notebook and start reviewing them and acting on them, something will eventually click.

* Master taxes. As already suggested, use tax-deductible retirement accounts (max them out if possible), but also do your taxes right. Use good tax software or hire a professional.

* Once you get started investing it becomes addictive and it's quite beautiful to watch your money grow. There is no guarantee there will be a future, but if there is, you might as well be rich there.

* Even if you lived on a desert island thousands of miles from anyone, you'd still need to allocate resources and make plans for the future if you wanted to survive.

* There are many types of economic systems, and certain fundamentals are found under all of them. Remember the arbitrary nature of all money, and remember that most people don't realize its arbitrary nature, thus making it "real" (until a systemic collapse occurs).

* If you're reading this, there a good chance you already have more wealth than billions of people on this planet. Anyone who doesn't help others (with money and/or time and effort) and improve this world is investing not in the future, but in cruelty, war, sweatshops, violence, pollution, and death. Your level of financial security gives you more voice and great power. And as Spider-Man says, "With great power comes great responsibility." Invest in life. We can always find time and money to give back to the world.

RESOURCES

Think and Grow Rich – Napoleon Hill

The Science of Getting Rich – Wallace D. Wattles

Acres of Diamonds – Russell Conwell

The Art of Money-Getting – P.T. Barnum

Richistan – Robert Frank

I Will Teach You to Be Rich – Ramit Sethi

The Automatic Millionaire – David Bach

The 4-Hour Workweek – Timothy Ferriss

THE PRACTICE

Chapter 10:

MEDITATION

* "A person who thinks all the time has nothing to think about except thoughts. So he loses touch with reality and lives in a world of illusion." – Alan Watts

* Meditation has been so important in my own personal development that I was tempted to include it in the Essential Nine – however, there are other methods of deeply altering consciousness and I don't feel qualified to say that meditation is the only or best way for going deep. But in addressing the Essential Nine, meditation has enormously helped with my spiritual connection, moods, and health.

* I learned TM (Transcendental Meditation) when I was 17. I later learned and practiced other forms of meditation, but TM remains my daily practice of choice. I don't claim it's the "best" (whatever that means). It works for me and has definite physiological effects. People say that you shouldn't judge your meditations – and I don't – but I can tell when my practice is working.

* That being said, TM centers now charge over $2500 to learn TM. I think meditation shouldn't cost this much to learn, and if I'd had to pay that much I probably wouldn't have learned TM.

* You can learn some form of meditation from a book, an audio program, a class, or a person. Try different practices till you find one that works for you.

* Simply closing your eyes is not the same as meditating.

* Practice meditation daily. Making it a regular practice is the surest way to let its influence overwhelm you.

* It can be difficult to meditate when you're busy, feeling a lot of stress, traveling etc., but try to find that time each day.

* Meditation may change throughout your life. Trying to describe meditation and how it feels is largely ineffectual, but I'll try. My meditations usually consist of a soft, sweet feeling inside, and a relaxation deeper than sleep. Sometimes I have thoughts and continue to meditate deeply. Sometimes I stay on the surface but feel very refreshed. Sometimes I go very deep and lose my sense of identity.

* If you've never meditated then it might look like a waste of time to sit there doing nothing. Honestly? It's one of the most precious moments in every day of my life.

* The health benefits of meditation are definite. There are "reasons' for meditating. But that is not the purpose of meditation: "We could say that meditation doesn't have a reason or doesn't have a purpose. In this respect it's unlike almost all other things we do except perhaps making music and dancing. When we make music we don't do it in order to reach a certain point, such as the end of the composition. If that were the purpose of music then obviously the fastest players would be the best. Also, when we are dancing we are not aiming to arrive at a particular place on the floor as in a journey. When we dance, the journey itself is the point, as when we play music the playing itself is the point. And exactly the same thing is true in meditation. Meditation is the discovery that the point in life is always arrived at in the immediate present." – Alan Watts

* And although I see Alan Watts' point in the above quote, I also find that the more I meditate, the more I do things - everything - simply to do them, not to get any result. Meditation shows you how to inhabit every moment.

RESOURCES

Books and audio programs may be effective to learn meditation, but for anyone starting out I recommend finding a good teacher instead. Yoga centers, Zen and other Buddhist centers, colleges, and health centers all offer meditation classes. Find a good teacher and submerse yourself in the practice. It can change the very nature of your consciousness, and that will touch every part of your life. If you try one thing in this book that you never considered before, make it meditation.

Chapter 11:

BINAURAL BEATS, HYPNOSIS, PARALIMINALS (etc.)

* If you've struggled with meditation, try these technologies. They're sort of training wheels for meditation.

* Binaural beats are a sound technology that entrains brainwaves, allowing you to easily enter into different levels of rhythmic activity. The resulting states can be extremely relaxing.

* Hypnosis allows you to communicate directly to those parts of your body not under your conscious control. It too can be enormously relaxing, and allow you to overcome bad habits and fears, and spontaneously heal a variety of medical conditions. The limits of hypnosis seem to be the limits of an individual's beliefs.

* Paraliminals are an audio technique in which two unique narratives are presented in each ear (through headphones). The dual voices cause your brain to relax and learn at a deeper than conscious level. They are often used in conjunction with binaural beats. I prefer paraliminals to subliminals since you can always decipher the messages being sent. With subliminals you never know what messages you are receiving below the threshold of your hearing.

* Yoga nidra is a yogic technique employing relaxation and guided imagery. It is notably different from meditation and other forms of altering consciousness, and the quick onset of feeling can be quite astonishing. It may be experienced through audio recordings or with the help of a trained practitioner.

* There are thousands of guided imagery and meditation programs in existence, using combinations of speech, nature sounds, music, and binaural beats. Some are quite good and some are unbelievably bad.

* Ultimately I prefer meditation to any external guidance, but must admit that sometimes when I can't get the wheels going I turn to audio to help me get back on track. Plus I've gone to some INCREDIBLE places through various audio programs. Give them a try till you find one you like.

RESOURCES

First see my chapter on Open Source, P2P and Peer Culture. Go to the websites I suggest if you don't know how to use torrents. Once you get it set up, try the following searches and try some of the material out till you find what you like:

Binaural beats

Guided meditation

Hypnosis

Paraliminals

Yoga Nidra

Mantak Chia

Luanne Oakes

Effortless Success – Jack Canfield and Paul Scheele

Paul Scheele

Hemi-sync

Holosync

With most audio you want the highest quality possible. If you get audio files in a lossless format like flac files, you can play them straight from your computer using a VLC player (http://www.videolan.org/vlc/). Or you can convert them to another lossless format like wav files, which most mp3 players can play.

Chapter 12:

LUCID DREAMING

* I first heard of lucid dreaming around 1991, when I was in the 7th grade. I found a book on it at the library, and none of my friends or family had heard of it. It has since become fairly popular (thanks to movies like *Waking Life*), but when I found it I felt like I had discovered real magic. I would say it's the first time I was ever "high."

* And when you think about it, dreams are REALLY weird, right? You go to sleep and things "happen" in your head, and they kind of make sense, but then they kind of don't. What is that?!

* If you've never heard of lucid dreaming (or had a lucid dream): You're having a dream, and suddenly you realize you're dreaming (in the dream). Hopefully you won't wake up from overexcitement, and if you don't you can do pretty much anything you can imagine, with varying degrees of control over the dreamscape.

* The first step to learning lucid dreaming is to improve dream recall. Start keeping a dream journal. Keep a notepad near your bed and write down anything you remember about your dreams when you wake up, however vague. It may not be much at first, but if you keep at it you'll start to remember more. Eventually you can remember pages of detail.

* Some people have told me that they don't dream. Everyone dreams, or else you go crazy. They just don't have good dream recall. Before going to sleep, remind yourself that you're going to remember your dreams. Keep a note near your bed to remind you about journaling when you wake up. It can simply say, "What did you dream?" Ask yourself this first thing on waking.

* Start asking yourself (when awake) if you're dreaming. Seriously. Right now, for instance – how do you know you're not dreaming? Don't just brush the question off. There are several tests to see if you're dreaming. Ask yourself: What have I done today? Start with waking in the morning and go through your day to the present moment. Does it make sense? If it doesn't, seriously consider the idea that you might be dreaming. If it does make sense, you still might be dreaming. So take a look around and find some words. Any words will do, including the ones in this

sentence. Alright, now read the words. Then close your eyes or turn away for a second. Look back at the words you read. Are they the same? Have they changed? If they've changed, you're probably dreaming.

* Even if you don't master lucid dreaming, remembering your dreams is fascinating in itself. However, when a lucid dream hits it's amazing! The clarity, immortality, and freedom you feel is so overwhelming that you will often wake up with excitement.

* I'm guessing most people use their lucid dreams to have sex or fly, but lucid dreams also offer a stage for rehearsing things we might hesitate to do when awake, preparing us for the "real" thing.

RESOURCES

There are now countless books on lucid dreaming. There are also technologies like audio you play while sleeping and machinery you strap to your head or other body parts that supposedly help you realize you're dreaming. There are pills you can take (melatonin seems to enhance dream clarity) and tons of questionable fixes for initiating lucid dreams. These two books I recommend most for dream work:

Exploring the World of Lucid Dreaming – Stephen Laberge

The Teachings of Don Carlos – Victor Sanchez

And this is an interesting book with a good section on lucid dreaming:

The Head Trip – Jeff Warren

Chapter 13:

MENTORS

* Absorbing lessons through media is helpful, but there’s something about working with a mentor that catapults you to new levels much more quickly. A good mentor, coach, or teacher tailors the lesson to YOU.

* If one person can do it, YOU can do it. Mentors show you how. You still have to do the work.

* Being around a good mentor memetically transmits big ideas to you. Maybe it has to do with being around a different morphic field (see Rupert Sheldrake’s work). More than any information sent, mentors pass on possibility thinking that allows you to overcome your limiting beliefs.

* Mentors hold you accountable and push your limits.

* The same information can be found in books or on the internet, but there’s a learning curve and sometimes a mentor is the only thing that can get you over that hump.

* And sometimes getting your nose out of a book and in the game the only thing holding you back. Mentors throw you in the water and see how you swim.

* I haven’t found therapy as useful as mentors and teachers because the implicit assumption in most therapy is that something is wrong. Failure is not "something wrong." It is feedback. You can’t succeed without failure. Rather than analyzing why it went wrong ad nauseam, good mentors help you keep your eye on what you want.

* For the same reason I would rather brainstorm with a peer group (or mastermind group, to use Napoleon Hill’s term) of already successful people than drown in a support group of failures.

* Audio programs are the next best thing to mentors, I’ve found. A voice gets in your head the way a book can’t.

* Attending workshops, although lacking the long-term consistency of a mentor or class, can still be an enormous boost and great way to connect with people on similar paths.

* Get the BEST mentors! You probably won't find one mentor who's mastered every area of life. That's fine. Have your piano teacher help with your piano lessons. Have your fitness instructor show you the best way to flatten your belly. Have your grandma show you the best way to make Christmas cookies.

* A common statistic is that your income is equal to the average income of the five people you spend the most time with. Be around people who dream big. As with everything, make a conscious choice. I will beat it over your head because it's so important: MAKE A CONSCIOUS CHOICE!

* Some activities you'll find you can learn better through a book. But some things will NEED a mentor. For me, math, music, social activities, martial arts, and dancing are all areas that I needed mentors to get me going in the right direction.

* With foreign languages, there is no substitute for immersing yourself in a sea of native speakers (while simultaneously studying formally or semi-formally). Everyone becomes your mentor because they're all experts! And most native speakers will love to help you learn. Plus, you can't speak the "culture" in a book, and culture is a major part of any foreign language.

* I have a vision of an education system that demolishes traditional classroom learning. I think staying in the same school and neighborhood all year stifles the brain's ability to expand. Plus, tons of money could be saved by ditching the traditional classroom, similar to the savings gleaned by ditching the traditional office environment.

* Instead of one teacher handling a large group of kids, I think we should introduce (gradually, of course) a mentoring system in which every student is expected to one day become a mentor. Every student will work with several mentors and professional teachers over the course of the week and focus on a different area of study. Students might start to mentor other students around middle or high school age. It would depend on the student's ability and maturity (as rated by other mentors and teachers). Part of graduating high school would require you to put in a certain number of mentoring hours and demonstrate your ability to help others pass certain subjects. Other incentives (perhaps college grants or even cash) could be included in the program. Students would meet, say, once or twice a month with a larger group in a more traditional classroom.

* If this vision sounds myopic, think again. I've seen students stretch themselves and their abilities when they knew they had to do something to get a passing grade or graduate.

* Aside from financial advantage, I think this system would also promote a togetherness lacking in the current school system. Some kids are more anti-social than others and would require an alternate classroom environment, but I think most students are capable of working in a mentoring system if the parents and teachers are on board and willing to help a child adjust to an alternate system. The best way would just be to have students work with mentors from kindergarten onward and never get them to think being in a classroom for five days a week is normal.

* I think travel is also very beneficial to learning, and a mentoring system allows more flexibility for students traveling together in small groups (rather than massive and clunky field trips). Two teachers and twelve students can learn and travel much faster than ten teachers and eighty students. I would also like to see travel to foreign countries as a requirement to graduate high school. Travel doesn't have to be expensive and can actually accelerate learning, and students should witness the world firsthand.

RESOURCES

Where can you find mentors? Schools, your work, community centers… also, anyone you admire is a potential mentor. Now, it may be difficult to get Johnny Depp to mentor you, but many people you consider out of reach may actually be willing to meet or talk on the phone briefly once a month if you approach them right. But even if you can't get the most famous and exclusive mentors, you can still find people who know how to do what you want to do. Often they will do it for free or for lunch. The information gleaned in minutes can save you years of struggle. So figure out what you want to work on most and find someone who's good at it! And don't worry if they say no, there are millions of mentors out there. Tim Ferriss has some good info on tracking down "superstar" mentors in *The 4-Hour Workweek*.

MEDIA

Chapter 14:

BOOKS

* Books are easy. Books will never turn you away (even blind people can read books!). Books are small or huge, full of lies and truths, exquisite beauty and fond horrors. But perhaps you already know all this since you are reading one right now.

* I found books early and couldn't believe what I'd found. Some were good. Some seemed unpublishable and I couldn't understand why people praised them (*Moby Dick*, for instance, when I read it in high school). They hit you at different times in different ways. Never assume a book is "bad." It just might not be aligned with you right now. Maybe you should have read it at age 15, or maybe it'll fit you better when you're 50.

* When I was a kid I wanted to know everything and imagined reading every book from 000 to 999 (or however the books were organized). I don't think I made it very far in that project. But that insatiable curiosity is what I hope to inspire in you. I love that libraries exist and lend material for free. Take advantage of the wisdom of others! Books have been written on every subject. Figure out what you most want to learn and do with your life, and if you read a book a week on that subject you will be an expert in just a year or two. Spending a half hour browsing the library each week will force you to develop. Choose your brain-fuel carefully.

* Books contain the secret of EVERYTHING. You still have to go out and do the work – but books will give you a map. Very good books exist on every topic you can imagine.

* Use your library, but if you really like a book, buy a copy. Rereading will add depth to your understanding and bind books to your soul. I never reread books when I was younger because there are so many books I haven't read. But I now reread favorite books regularly – not for the information, but to re-experience and savor the texture.

* Books let you be inside another person's head. What about you? What story are you ready to tell?

* I think everyone has at least one book inside them, whether it’s an autobiography or a collection of ideas to guide them, like this book.

* "All I mark as my own you shall offset it with your own,

Else it were time lost listening to me." – Walt Whitman

* Start a blog, even if you don’t know what you’ll write about. Giving yourself a forum invites the universe to give you ideas, and it will.

* Write an ebook - it's never been easier to get your book online.

RESOURCES

For writing:

On Writing – Stephen King

The Craft of Writing Science Fiction That Sells – Ben Bova

The War of Art – Steven Pressfield

Some favorite novels:

Ulysses – James Joyce

True Hallucinations – Terence McKenna

On the Road – Jack Kerouac

Naked Lunch – William Burroughs

War and Peace – Leo Tolstoy

Candide – Voltaire

The Dice Man – Luke Rhinehart

Behold the Man – Michael Moorcock

The Illuminatus! Trilogy – Robert Shea and Robert Anton Wilson

The Great Gatsby – F. Scott Fitzgerald

1984 – George Orwell

The Sound and the Fury – William Faulkner

The Princess Bride – William Goldman

The Third Policeman – Flann O'Brien

The Secret Agent – Joseph Conrad

The Man in the High Castle – Philip K. Dick

The Door Into Summer – Robert Heinlein

2001 – Arthur C. Clarke

The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy – Douglas Adams

A Study in Scarlet – Arthur Conan Doyle

The Time Machine – H.G. Wells

King Solomon's Mines – H. Rider Haggard

Inherent Vice – Thomas Pynchon

The Martian Tales (11 volumes) – Edgar Rice Burroughs

Cat's Cradle – Kurt Vonnegut, Jr.

Voice of the Fire – Alan Moore

Pale Fire – Vladimir Nabokov

Brave New World – Aldous Huxley

The Wasp Factory – Iain Banks

Fahrenheit 451 – Ray Bradbury

A Clockwork Orange – Anthony Burgess

The Tetherballs of Bougainville – Mark Leyner

Alice in Wonderland and Through the Looking Glass – Lewis Carroll

The Lady in the Lake – Raymond Chandler

Under the Volcano – Malcolm Lowry

Chapter 15:

MUSIC

* "Hell is other people's music." – Momus

* Music could possibly be the oldest art form. We have instruments from around 7000 BC, but it surely goes back much further than that with singing and drumming.

* Like dew on the leaves of a tree, music clings to the mind and fills it with mood. In fact, music is one of the easiest ways to instantly alter mood. This being the case, you'd think we would choose music that consistently makes us feel good. Not so. A look at popular music today shows a landscape of whiny self-pitying losers, anger, and mediocre imitations of what was original thirty or forty years ago. We couldn't create a more depressing moodscape if we tried.

* The underlying core of music will always be there, unchanged, and the current state of music is a blip in the cosmos.

* So many crucial scenes in movies rely upon music to control your mood and how you respond to a scene. Rare and satisfying is the movie that can get by with little or no music, such as *No Country for Old Men*. I love music, but iPods and ubiquitous speakers in the walls has made a world with too much music, and most of it is treacly dull. The silence between sounds, the quiet space around words – being able to turn sound off makes it more enjoyable when it is on. A mind always receiving input has no chance for inspired and original output.

* Music without language.

* Music in a language you don't speak.

* Accidental music.

* Music is wallpaper, colors. Foreign music offers so many different colors. Don't limit yourself to one genre. Genius is found everywhere. Often it's just covered in crap.

* Can we have some new themes, some fresh feelings? Genius can go any direction, so please, let's move beyond the ennui and anger that have dominated music for the last 50 years.

* The options for music at the beginning of the 21st Century are phenomenal. Let us choose the best delicacies and not glut our stomachs on a diet of cardboard music.

* The world needs your music. Piano and guitar classes are available at most community colleges. Home-recording equipment and software have never been more accessible and cheap.

* I wrote this chapter while listening to the clothes dryer spin.

RESOURCES

Rather than list all the albums that have influenced me, I'm just going to recommend three of my all-time favorite musicians. These are artists I've never grown tired of and who are always revealing new things to me:

Mozart - king of music. I don't think any other music is so utterly re-listenable. The scope of Mozart's work boggles the mind and his ability to create an environment of sound, an entire world, elevated Western music to a new level.

J.S. Bach - For similar reasons to Mozart, but in some ways even more subdued, nuanced.

Brian Eno - a giant. I especially recommend: *Discreet Music* (I've probably played the title track over 1000 times), *Music for Airports*, and his four "pop" albums from the 70s: *Here Come The Warm Jets*, *Taking Tiger Mountain (by Strategy)*, *Another Green World*, and *Before and After Science*.

Chapter 16:

COMICS

* "I'd like to think that if I've shown anything, it's that comics are the medium of almost inexhaustible possibilities, that there have been...there are great comics yet to be written. There are things to be done with this medium that have not been done, that people maybe haven't even dreamed about trying. And, if I've had any benign influence upon comics, I would hope that it would be along those lines; that anything is possible if you approach the material in the right way. You can do some extraordinary things with a mixture of words and pictures. It's just a matter of being diligent enough and perceptive enough and working hard enough, continually honing your talent until it's sharp enough to do the job that you require." – Alan Moore

* Picking up a copy of *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles Adventures* in 1988 changed my life. I must have seen comics before, but they suddenly became something magical.

* I found comic stores and was hooked, making monthly pilgrimages to pick up Batman, Superman and anything else I was reading.

* As I got older I followed writers and artists more than characters. I started seeing the comics medium itself as a fabulous amorphous blob of pure potentiality.

* People continue to see comics as a children's medium. Why is that? Yes, the content has its roots in material aimed at kids. But the medium's limitations were largely self-imposed.

* When I read comics authors like Grant Morrison and Alan Moore I found people who seemed to understand the angst and existential weirdness of being alive. These were comics that spoke to me more than any story I'd ever seen or read in books or TV.

* Comics as a medium are not a recent phenomenon. They exploded in the 20th century largely because of cheap printing. But comics may be our oldest recorded communication medium. Before books, our ancestors recorded in caves the stories

of the hunt. Like music, comics originally communicated without words, bringing to life a liquid narrative of indefinite waves and mutating times.

* Do comics use both hemispheres of the brain more than prose? It's certainly worth scientific study. We do know that people learn faster with images than words alone, so I'd like to see comics a part of every student's education.

* In their modern form, comics have some of the finest writers and artists alive in all history. Comics are everywhere, from airline safety cards to textbooks, and understanding their form and dynamic will give you an edge, as with any radically different medium. Comics do things that prose and film can not do, that only comics can do. They are certainly not a mere combination of other media.

RESOURCES

The Invisibles – Grant Morrison and artists

The League of Extraordinary Gentlemen – Alan Moore and Kevin O'Neill

David Boring – Daniel Clowes

Sin City – Frank Miller

Sandman: Fables and Reflections – Neil Gaiman and artists

Quimby the Mouse – Chris Ware

Marvels – Kurt Busiek and Alex Ross

Bone – Jeff Smith

Madman: The Oddity Odyssey

Ode to Kirihito – Osamu Tezuka

Low Moon – Jason

Good-bye – Yoshihiro Tatsumi

Moomin – Tove Jansson

Understanding Comics – Scott McCloud

Chapter 17:

VISUAL ARTS

* As a boy I decided I had to draw comics. I knew people (mainly men) were being paid to put stories on paper. I wanted to do that.

* One day I was with my brother and dad and I begged to go to Crown Books (RIP) to find a copy of Stan Lee and John Buscema's *How to Draw Comics the Marvel Way*. I had read a library copy of it and finally decided that now was the time (11 years old or so) to take art seriously and that I had to have that book to study religiously, and once I had it running through my blood I would know how to make comics (the Marvel way) like a pro.

* Well, my dad acceded to my request and I got the book. I gave it many hours of my time and (needless to say) it didn't quite have everything I needed to make it as a comic artist. I would need more. I quickly found art books by Burne Hogarth (a great artist but his books aren't very instructive) and Jack Hamm. It was with Hamm that I found my niche. Here was a man who knew how to whittle out the nuance of line and space and teach it. His pages were crammed with cheat codes of the art world, and to this day I love his books.

* The type of drawing I was doing is what I call cartooning. Even if it's very realistic, I'm drawing from memory or standardized drawing techniques that don't require a model or photo to reference. I actually prefer cartooning since I have little interest in drawing realistically. However…

* When I got to college I took drawing classes and suddenly we were doing things differently. We put fruit on a table and drew it. We had models and drew them. Sometimes we didn't even look at the paper. We turned off the left side of the brain and just drew what we saw, not giving it a name. This is a much more realistic style of drawing, and it feels different.

* When you get in flow with drawing on the right side of the brain (as Betty Edwards puts it) time moves differently. Thoughts slow or vanish, and the drawing is virtually automatic.

* Both styles of drawing, cartooning and realistic drawing, open up entirely new ways of thinking, and I recommend learning both. Many people say things like "I can't draw" or "I'm not artistic," which is like someone saying they can't do handwriting because they never learned and it looks hard. Of course it looks hard if you've never done it! But drawing (especially realistic drawing) has a quick learning curve and with a little instruction you'll be amazed at the work you're doing.

* Once you've learned pencil drawing basics you can go off in so many other directions: painting, pastels, charcoal, abstract materials and techniques. Just get started and enjoy being "bad" at the beginning. Savor that process and know that time and consistent effort inevitably improve your skill.

* Start thinking of yourself as a creative and artistic person. There is nothing you are incapable of if you release those chains from your mind. You are not a business man or a mechanic or a flower seller. You do things, but your definition of yourself is as fluid as you want it to be.

* Learn to enjoy the process of drawing, regardless of results, and you'll always be successful. Drawing can be extremely relaxing.

* Classes really vary in art instruction. It's often better to have a one-on-one mentor, or even just some good drawing books or videos. Bombard yourself with different methods until you find one you love.

RESOURCES

Drawing on the Right Side of the Brain – Betty Edwards

Drawing the Head and the Figure – Jack Hamm

Cartooning the Head and Figure – Jack Hamm (anything by Hamm, actually)

How to Draw Comics the Marvel Way – Stan Lee and John Buscema

Chapter 18:

CONVERSATION AND THE SPOKEN WORD

* "A single conversation across the table with a wise person is worth a month's study of books." – Chinese Proverb

* There are few better examples of the medium being the message than the spoken word. We speak and listen not just for information, but to have closeness with others, to see faces, to feel other people and laugh with them.

* When we want to be bowled over with information, we read. When we want to experience the duality of being, we have a conversation.

* Don’t limit your conversation to the same people all the time or you will have a very limited muscle. Speak with new people every day.

* I’ve lived alone many times, and many times I listened to audio programs several hours a day as I did other things. It improved my listening skills immensely.

* Listen to great speakers. Attitudes, inflections, cadence, thought patterns, experimentation and humor are all contagious.

* Develop genuine curiosity when talking with others. It doesn’t have to be faked. Ask good questions and figure out what motivates people, what they desire and why, what their philosophy of life is, and what has led them to this moment in time.

* Talk clearly.

* Talk loudly, but don’t be abrasively loud.

* Have slightly more energy in your speech than the person you’re talking to. Too much energy and you’ll come off as Woody Woodpecker. Too little and the person will fall asleep and lose interest. Just slightly more than their speed.

* Listen to self-help programs.

* Listen to stand-up comedy.

* Listen to comedy albums.

* Listen to live speeches.

* Listen to audiobooks.

* Listen to poetry.

* Make your own recordings. Release them online or save them for your grandchildren or for yourself to remind yourself what you once sounded like.

* The most abstract prose or poetry has nothing on human speech patterns and conversation: forever evolving, flowing.

* Listen and give your full attention. Care. Don't judge or give advice. Listen.

* Send love and smiles with your eyes.

RESOURCES

Books on conversation aren't as helpful as talking itself, but this one is a classic in the self-help literature:

How to Win Friends and Influence People – Dale Carnegie

For practice, seek out ten new people every day to have a short conversation with. It can be about anything. Ask good questions, and LISTEN so you can ask even better questions. To improve your listening skills, use audiobooks regularly. Some of my favorite speech recordings are by: Alan Watts, Terence McKenna, Anthony Robbins, Allen Ginsberg, and Alan Moore.

Chapter 19:

FILM

* Perhaps film seems more "real" than other media because it’s the closest thing to capturing the physical experience of a person and it mimics time more regularly.

* Film seems like a close approximation of reality – because of this it’s been more easily used for propaganda (as predicted by Orwell and Bradbury in the 40s and 50s).

* In a Gutenberg galaxy we were a world of readers. In a film galaxy we are a world of watchers.

* The 20th century needed a medium that could capture the A-bomb, Jimi Hendrix smashing his guitar on stage, and Charlie Chaplin dottering along a sidewalk with a cane, not "doing" anything, just existing on film, in time. Our vision of the 20th century is completely different from the 19th century because of film. Has film been the key factor in the 20th century’s rapid acceleration?

* We remember via the dominant media forms. We remember 20th century epochs based on the dominant cinematography at the time. Film mutated so rapidly that every decade has a unique look. I love the crisp black and white of the 1940s.

* Film and music are extroverted, invasive media.

* The 2000s were the IMAX decade: gaudy, 9/11, materialism, global destruction, explosions.

* IMAX: a screen so wide you have to turn your head to see it all.

* Because of the hummer-like loudness and abrasion of film, we don’t think of stories in prose and comics as "legitimate" until they’re transferred to film. Isn’t a story just as complete without being filmed? Or does it have to be absorbed on the mass, tribal level? Somehow the film is the END of a story. Once it’s a film it’s MADE IT. Never vice versa. No one says, "Gosh, when are they going to adapt *Citizen Kane* to prose?"

* The best adaptations should never be a direct "literal" adaptation. Kubrick is a great example because most of his films are based on books. But many of the authors – Stephen King, Anthony Burgess – were unsatisfied with his adaptations. But who cares? As far as I'm concerned, a book and movie of the same story might as well be completely unrelated.

* When I suggest to people they do work they like to do, they tell me they don't like to do anything enough to make it their job. But then they go and watch five movies a week! Get involved! Make your own movies! It's infinitely more rewarding. And with video-hosting sites like youtube, anyone can get started on short films quickly and cheaply. Any media you love should get your love by having you involved as a producer, not just a consumer.

* I've heard that the unconscious can't distinguish between film and reality. I'm not a prude, but there's no shortage of violence in film and video games, and when you're inundated with that it becomes your worldview, your techne for solving problems. Take responsibility for what you become.

* Make film a special event, a unique experience. Instead of every night, how about once a month. Suddenly every film provides a wealth of thought.

RESOURCES

Most people watch too much television and movies as it is, so I don't think I need to list my favorite directors or films. Instead I'll list a book that might make you watch less film:

Four Arguments for the Elimination of Television – Jerry Mander

And maybe you'll use the time you free up to make films and put them online!

Chapter 20:

INTERNET

* Addiction takes many forms, and one of the largest unrecognized (except in China and Korea) addictions of the modern world is the internet. Everyone knows it’s great, amazing, changed the world blah blah blah. But every tool has the potential for abuse.

* "You can not step into the same internet twice." – Heraclitus

* More than any media today, the world would greatly benefit if it took a collective break from the internet. It is so addictive because it has a rat-in-a-cage quality of inconsistent rewards (let me check my email) and always has something to waste your time (as I write this a Marshall McLuhan documentary plays across the room on my laptop [I write with a pen]). Yes, I can be an addict myself, which is why the occasional internet outage or media fast while traveling (or otherwise) is a good thing.

* I want the internet to be there when I need it, like a dictionary on a bookshelf. I don’t want to read the dictionary all the time.

* "The first thing to ask of any technology, any tool, is, ‘What will this thing enhance?’" – Marshall McLuhan

* I would not be living where I am without the internet. I would be doing different work, know different people, and be a different person. More than anything, the internet connects things that would otherwise go their way separately. It connects people to causes they want to participate in, to dreams they might otherwise be unable to follow, and most importantly, to people. The micro-niching of the internet means there is someone out there with your interests (however unusual), people who fit you.

* If you don’t control the way the internet interacts with your life, you will be knocked off the road. I think most people know this by now, but I would be remiss if I didn’t give a nod to the internet. Like books, it has been a portal to many other "secrets" I’ve discovered.

* At some point, using a computer and using the internet became inseparable. It is a part of our senses now, and we can't go back to closing our eyes. We can only strive for clearer, truer vision.

* I've worked with many kids in my life. In that time I've seen kids who are incredibly smart, more than I remember kids being when I was young. Maybe this is just the mind's trickery, but I think it's more than that. As Steven Johnson describes in *Everything Bad is God for You*, it really does seem like media is increasing certain types of intelligence. Yes, I subscribe to theories of multiple intelligences, and from what I see kids are becoming better at transmitting and receiving communication signals.

* "Anyone who makes a distinction between education and entertainment understands neither." – Marshall McLuhan

* Kids are getting their real education from TV and movies and internet, not classrooms. They're buying gaudy shoes and throwing them away in two months, stealing music from poor, defenseless corporations, and downloading mountains of porn. Yes, kids love porn. I said it. Porn continues its process of entering the mainstream and kids know all about it. It's weird for even a thirty-something like me to hear grade school kids using sex terms. I don't know how much they really understand at that age, what they have actually experienced, but with all information just a google search away, I think they know more than I did as a kid. However, it has a glamorized no-ill-effects smear that porn is known for. They see the unprotected sex but not the HIV-positive test results. They see lust, not love. I don't know what the long-term effects will be and I'm not here to judge. I just make a note.

* People use the internet at different operational levels. They may be drawn to the internet to buy things or get music or porn or whatever, but often move up to "higher" things. By "higher" I just mean a more self-directed, interactive, and consciously applied internet. I have seen this evolution take place many times. People have a desire to know things, much as they have a desire to try new things and be treated fairly. No one has to settle for an ad-saturated internet, spam, and coercive marketing tactics.

* The internet has witnessed a rise in stuff culture, which is an observational platform for seeing the world, a way of following the cultural and political zeitgeist. But instead of focusing on traditionally newsworthy events and entertainment artifacts, this mode of viewing the world follows trends by taking note of stuff. By stuff, I could be speaking of almost anything. Therein lies the

usefulness of the term. Stuff culture seeks to document any facet of any phenomenon so long as it contains some quirk of interest.

* Once a person realizes he can find an answer on Wikipedia (usually somewhat accurate), he will go and look up the most trivial info. I know people who would be first in line to have a brain implant that connects them 24/7 to the internet. People like to be connected, feel the presence of others, and know. They might still be wasting time on things like porn (n.b. I keep pointing to porn because it is the best example of diluting the will and focus of an individual from his true dreams. My objection is not moral, and I think the only censorship should be self-censorship) and just living as a cog in Rupert Murdoch's myspace empire, but they might sell things on craigslist or connect, blog, share, and grow.

* The brands are everywhere, the corporations. They are a method of structuring large groups of people (as are organizations, churches, non-profits, clubs). Ultimately they are not good are bad. They serve as a structure for interaction, and some interactions are more beautiful than others. Take Google, the strongest brand ever. They have made their profit through a service that requires no physical product and minimal customer service. I think Google is generally a more benign structure than, say, Exxon, but who knows? Part of that is the company's image and how it deals with people.

* If you're going to participate in the internet and not just observe, people gravitate toward these qualities:

1. Support a user's desire to know anything and experience any media for FREE.

2. Allow a user the opportunity to do ANYTHING anyone else has done (lack of hierarchy).

3. Connects a user to anyone the user wants to connect to.

* Whatever intrinsic forces are at work on the internet, I think the overall McLuhan-esque effect is to promote peace, justice, and art. It is bonding us together as a species and allowing a concentrated effort to save a planet that has faltered, and it encourages us to do this outside of traditional government and without borders.

* Perhaps it makes us smarter in some ways by using different parts of the brain in its artistic collage technique. Perhaps it makes us dumber in some ways by constantly multitasking and being engulfed by marketing campaigns. And what

about the effects on health of sitting in front of a monitor for hours on end. Sedentary activity is taking its toll.

* It makes us all artist and audience. It spreads the human voice and allows us to be in other places in a way only surpassed by the ease of modern travel.

* It is the great magical tool of our times. The tools we use shape us.

RESOURCES

Frontline: "Digital Nation" – February 2, 2010

Everything Bad is Good for You – Steven Johnson

Chapter 21:

TOUCH

* Hug your friends, families, co-workers. You or your culture may not be comfortable with this… so change. We need physical contact to be healthy.

* Make every day of your life Free Hug Day.

* Did you know that kids who don't get regular hugs from their parents statistically engage in sex earlier? If you're not getting love from your family, you look elsewhere.

* All of the senses can be dulled by abuse and overexposure. But how can you know your limits if you don't stretch yourself from time to time? Life is felt most at the extremities.

* Right now the internet is virtually dead to touch. People go to desk jobs and don't touch anything but a keyboard for eight hours. Surely this isn't the way. The internet will eventually catch up and involve all our senses more, but right now it's a flaccid imitation of life. Life is interaction, a breeze, a cactus, a kiss. Right now the internet does not provide these.

* Marijuana gives you supertouch.

* Does touch generally get weaker, like hearing and sight? Does this mean we need more massages and hugs as we grow older?

* Get a pet if you don't have a significant other. If you can't have a dog or cat get a lizard or hamster. If you can't have an animal, get a plant. Connecting to life keeps us alive.

* Each form of massage is its own language, its own genre of music.

* I think our breadth and depth of touch has been limited by our environment, and that as we continue to explore the brain we will tap new sensations in touch that it's impossible to currently imagine. We'll be able to download physical sensations and the addictive quality of the internet will increase a thousandfold. They won't need Skynet – this is how computers will take over.

* Will I vouch for every form of alternative therapy like reiki, acupuncture, craniosacral, qigong, reflexology etc? Of course not – most I haven't even tried yet. These therapies may be questionable. So try them. That is what this book is about: exploring and not relying on the reports of others.

Chapter 22:

THEATER, ACTING, MASKS, IMPROV, AND PUBLIC SPEAKING

* "I regard the theatre as the greatest of all art forms, the most immediate way in which a human being can share with another the sense of what it is to be a human being." – Oscar Wilde

* I didn't learn to relax in front of audiences till I became a full-time teacher in South Korea. Going in front of 38 students 4 or 5 times a day, five days a week, is guaranteed to alter your view of public speaking.

* "Acting is half shame, half glory. Shame at exhibiting yourself, glory when you can forget yourself." – John Gielgud

* You've probably heard the statistic that public speaking is feared more than death. Like most fears, it's actually something that can make us stronger and eventually become FUN.

* Learning to improvise in front of crowds is a muscle that can be strengthened.

* Acting reminds us not to take our everyday ego so seriously. Our ego is a mask as much as any stage persona.

* "You're more likely to act yourself into feeling than feel yourself into action. So act! Whatever it is you know you should do, do it."

* Take time to try on new personalities. You can borrow the personalities of famous characters or your friends. You can try any personality that interests you, but if you choose people who you perceive as intelligent, courageous, witty, or any trait you want, you can tap those traits. This may be challenging around people who want you to behave like the "old you", so you may want to go somewhere no one knows you to test these personalities out. Travel is also a great opportunity to do this.

* Performing in front of others may initially be stressful, but stick with it and that energy will transform into a natural high. This may take weeks or months, but the change will come.

* "All the world's a stage,

And all the men and women merely players;

They have their exits and their entrances,

And one man in his time plays many parts,

His acts being seven ages."

- *As You Like It*, Act 2, scene 7, 139–143, William Shakespeare

RESOURCES

Be Heard Now! – Lee Glickstein

Impro – Keith Johnstone

Find a public speaking group such as Toastmasters or take a public speaking, acting, or improv class.

IMMERSION

Chapter 23:

TRAVEL

* "Traveling creates anew like nothing else. Go on your own. Go with a good heart and with only enough fear to spur you on. Throw yourself upon the mercy of the world and learn to get by in countries where no-one speaks your language. Come home changed forever and get on with being what you want to be and already are if you'd just get on with it. Imagine every dream come true in vivid detail, then work out the simple steps towards those dreams and start taking them, step by step until the dream enfolds you. Do everything you've never done because no-one else will want or care to do it for you. Time doesn't wait; we are Here To Go and there's only one Now." - Grant Morrison

* The opportunities to travel are unbelievable. Never before in history has it been so easy to move across the Earth, to see every continent, and to experience cultures on their own terms. To not take advantage of travel is like not reading books, never trying beer or ice cream, or never jumping in the waves at the beach. It is an essential part of being a modern citizen of the world.

* When you travel, things are suddenly different for no apparent reason, and you realize how much of your own culture is arbitrary. People are suddenly bowing instead of shaking hands. You don’t understand a word of what is being said. The architecture, furniture, climate, and bathrooms are all tweaked – sometimes the change is so small you can’t put your finger on what’s different. Drugs and sexual practices are frowned on or illegal in some countries. Cross a few borders and those same things are suddenly okay. All is in flux, you are forced to think differently and at new rates, and time does things you never thought possible. Travel allows us to see that the life we’re born into is not the all and everything of reality, and that we may fit better elsewhere. We become different people in different places. And my God – the food!

* Travel does so many things to develop personality, increase maturity, and push abilities, that I think it should be a part of every person’s lifelong education. It requires us to:

1. Accept and love the world and its people as they are now.

2. Take responsibility for everything, including things that are not your "fault", and do your best to help the world and its people.

* Anyone who travels will see how unfair the world is, how poorly designed, and how much better it could be. Can you imagine peace in the Middle East? Can you imagine Beijing or Mexico City with clean air? I want "peace, love, and understanding" to be the new definition of globalism. Travel forces us beyond provincial localism. We are citizens of the Universe, not any tribe. Move beyond cultural pride and shame and recognize that every culture has something valuable and horrible inside it. All we can do is embrace the beautiful. Worldblurring and information exchange are essential for world survival. Islamic fundamentalists, Chinese censorship, the Patriot Act… these and other attempts at control are the last grips of the past on the throat of the young. But people want to explore and embrace other cultures. Travel promotes peace. Travel creates love. Border laws and restrictions are mental restrictions and they serve to maintain slavery.

* In January 2005 I sat on a bustling street corner in Fes, Morocco. I had spent the day getting lost in medieval alleyways and avoiding guides hoping to scam some dirham off hapless Westerners. I was sick of Morocco, sick of traveling, lonely and nauseous for someone familiar. It was rush hour in the city and everyone was rushing home to have dinner with loved ones, I guess. Nearby sat a beggar who was missing a leg that lie exposed and gangrenous, nasty. Nobody but me seemed to notice. As I sat there in a city that didn't drink, all I could think was that a lot of the world would be better off if people learned to relax into every moment, to savor every concrescence of reality that flowed through consciousness, and to see every soul as a brother and sister. I rocked back and forth as I sat, trying to place a spell on the place, asking it to slow down and love itself. Naïve, I know. I don't know if the spell worked for Fes or the world (or for me).

* I relate this moment in time, a moment that is still taking place somewhere, not to frown on Morocco or its people, who are really the same as people anywhere (even if they don't drink alcohol). No, I tell it to you because it is a moment in which I stood outside of culture. It was an epiphany that might never have taken place were it not for the magic of travel.

* Travel (and reality in general) gives us the lessons we need, not the ones we want.

* There is so much work to do. I actually dislike the travel part of travel – airports, luggage, fatigue…. But I love to be in new places. I like to live in a place for a few months if possible, really feeling the culture out. J. Maarten Troost, Timothy Ferriss, Rolf Potts, Bruce Chatwin, all have great tips on this. And I think the travel process is getting better. A lot of the problems are aesthetic. I would rather travel leisurely on a relaxing train or ship than be crunched into an airplane or car for ten hours. I want beautiful airports and highways, moving beyond the utilitarian into the realm of the gorgeous. Let's focus on healing the environment, on beauty and elegance, and not make speed the number one priority. High-speed trains are cool. But so are zeppelins. Air pollution and noisy engines are not cool. Let's move travel away from the oil industry and into the realm of Star Trek. We can do this.

* The more you travel, the easier it becomes. Patterns emerge.

* You don't need to stay in expensive hotels when traveling. Hostels are usually much cheaper than hotels, especially in developed countries. But you don't even need to stay in hostels thanks to websites like Couchsurfing and Global Freeloaders.

* Guidebooks can be an okay resource, but don't live your life by them. Talk to the locals, keep your eyes open, and don't skip a restaurant just because it's not in the book.

* After a while I began to see the impossibility of travel. Everywhere is the same HERE. It becomes impossible to travel so I go to further and further extremes. But it's always the same HERE, the same NOW.

* I can dream, and dreams are the portal to the future. My advice to all people has always been: learn as much of the language and culture as possible, and explore as much as you can.

RESOURCES

Couchsurfing.org is my favorite travel website.

As I said above, don't totally rely on travel books, but for getting the gist of a place try Lonely Planet and Rough Guides for generally good info. Travel books are inevitably a little out of date.

Vagabonding – Rolf Potts

The 4-Hour Workweek – Timothy Ferriss

Lost on Planet China – J. Maarten Troost

In Patagonia – Bruce Chatwin

Chapter 24:

SEX

* "Is it not life? Is it not the thing?" – Lord Byron

* "Some things are better than sex, and some are worse, but there's nothing exactly like it." – W.C. Fields

* "Sex contains all, bodies, souls

Meanings, proofs, purities, delicacies, results, promulgations,

Songs, commands, health, pride, the maternal

Mystery, the seminal milk,

All hopes, benefactions, bestowals, all the

Passions, loves, beauties,

Delights of the earth."

- Walt Whitman

* Any book about the most wonderful things in life would be incomplete without a chapter on sex.

* In the sex-saturated imagery of the 21st century it's easy to take sex for granted by its very ubiquitous nature. Like music, everyone seems to have definite feelings about it. Everyone loves it. For the few who don't like music (and by analogy, sex), it's likely that they haven't heard the right stuff or given it a chance.

* I feel that love is the core of the Relationships chapter, which is why I didn't call this section Love. Love is often detached from sex anyway, especially today. This is unfortunate, because love coupled with sex is one of the deepest levels of ecstasy we can hope to achieve. It can take sex beyond the satisfaction of the ego.

* Sex has many levels, and there's isn't necessarily a right or wrong way to do it. But inflicting pain on others (unless specifically requested) is usually bad karma.

"You cannot hurt others without hurting yourself." Sex is about giving as much as receiving. That almost sounds too obvious to bother writing, but it is so easy to fall into relationships that are parasitic, submissive, or… unremarkable.

* "Give pleasure. Accept pleasure. It's that easy." – Kenneth Hanes

* "Chastity… the most unnatural of all the sexual perversions." – Aldous Huxley

* "Yes, I haven't had enough sex." – Sir John Betjeman, British poet laureate. He had been asked whether he had any regrets, in an interview for the television documentary Time With Betjeman (February 1983).

* Even if you don't master Tantric or Taoist sexual practices, everyone can learn Kegel exercises. These simple exercises can be performed anywhere while sitting or standing, discreetly, and are well-explained in *The Multi-Orgasmic Man* or through an internet search.

RESOURCES

There are more sexual resources out there than I could fit in this book. Get over your embarrassment and go browse at a sex shop like Good Vibrations. Don't be afraid to ask questions and be honest about your desires. The people working there are used to it. Here are two of my favorite sex books:

The Multi-Orgasmic Couple – Mantak Chia

She Comes First – Ian Kerner

Chapter 25:

DRUGS

* "A psychedelic experience is a journey to new realms of consciousness. The scope and content of the experience is limitless, but its characteristic features are the transcendence of verbal concepts, of space-time dimensions, and of the ego or identity. Such experiences of enlarged consciousness can occur in a variety of ways: sensory deprivation, yoga exercises, disciplined meditation, religious or aesthetic ecstasies, or spontaneously. Most recently they have become available to anyone through the ingestion of psychedelic drugs such as LSD, psilocybin, mescaline, DMT, etc. Of course, the drug does not produce the transcendent experience. It merely acts as a chemical key — it opens the mind, frees the nervous system of its ordinary patterns and structures." – Timothy Leary

* I led a pretty sedate and tame upbringing. I didn't try cigarettes or alcohol till I was out of high school. The first time I really smoked was when I was 18 or 19. I went to a neighbor's house and smoked pot with a few others. I had read authors like Grant Morrison who really showed the world of drugs in a new light (a far cry from my Orange County existence). I was curious, and though I barely got a buzz off the weed that day, I knew there was more.

* A few months later (this was in 1999) my family and I moved. We settled in a new neighborhood and I was bored, had no friends. My life from age 12 to 21 was pretty much hell, or so it seemed at the time. I went online one day and found a guy selling mushroom spores. I had recently become fascinated by Terence McKenna's descriptions of psychedelics, especially psilocybin mushrooms, and had to try them. I placed my order so I could grow them myself.

* The spore syringe arrived (with instruction booklet) and I got the necessary supplies. I went to a fish store and got a glass tank. I went to the hardware store and got canning jars, horticultural vermiculite and an ice pick. This was in May in Southern California and the clerk looked at me funny when I asked for an ice pick, but I didn't care. I was determined to get drugs.

* I grew them in my closet and as far as I know my parents never found out about the mushrooms. I checked the humidity often and cared for those mushrooms like children.

* "The psychedelics are a red-hot social issue, ethical issue, whatever the term for it is, and it is precisely because they are a deconditioning agents: they will cast doubt in you if you are a Hasidic rabbi, a Marxist anthropologist, or an altar boy, because their business is to dissolve belief systems, and they do this very well and then they leave you with the raw datum of experience, what William James called in infants 'the blooming, buzzing experience.' And out of that you reconstruct the world, and you need to understand that it is a dialogue where your decisions, the projection of your grammar onto the intellectual space in front of you, is going to gel into the mode of being. We actually create our own universe because we are all operating with our own private languages." – Terence McKenna

* When I'd grown enough mushrooms for what I guessed would be a good trip, I ate them up. They were bitter and nasty and I forced myself to get through them all.

* Then it all came tumbling down.

* I can't begin to tell you what I experienced on that first mushroom trip. I saw the future, the past. I vanished. I talked with my cat. Space-time became an amniotic fluid, both frozen and moving. All moments affecting all moments, I was outside and inside of everything. Any book or movie or whatever that attempts to describe a huge, deep trip like that will fail. I can't even fully describe or remember it now, but every time I trip I understand it a little better and bring some more back. But it is infinite so there's always more to explore.

* In the nine years since that first trip I've done many drugs: salvia, LSD, marijuana, 5-MeO DMT, ayahuasca, kava. I know there are many other drugs I haven't tried, but I'm not looking to try them all. In fact, these days I might only trip out once or twice a year. I find meditation and exercise more satisfying on a daily basis.

* "The only abuse of drugs is the control of drugs by other people. ...The only control is self-control." – Timothy Leary

* That being said, psychedelics, done properly, will blow your socks off. They are soo so shocking. Earth shatteringly shocking. REAL MAGIC. Really, really weird.

* "Don't take LSD [or any psychedelic] unless you are very well prepared, unless you are specifically prepared to go out of your mind. Don't take it unless you have someone that's very experienced with you to guide you through it. And don't take it unless you are ready to have your perspective on yourself and your life radically

changed, because you're gonna be a different person, and you should be ready to face this possibility." – Timothy Leary

* If you could anticipate the change, it would not be revolutionary. True education is a surprise. You won't get the teaching you want – you'll get the teaching you need.

* "I am 100 percent in favor of the intelligent use of drugs, and 1,000 percent against the thoughtless use of them, whether caffeine or LSD. And drugs are not central to my life." – Timothy Leary

* Drugs are everywhere. It is our food, our drinks, our air.

* Drug abuse is the habit, not the drug.

* My most valuable guides to the psychedelic experience have been Terence McKenna, James Joyce, Grant Morrison, Alan Moore, Joseph Campbell, an understanding of Hermetic Qabalah and the Tarot, 70s rock and roll lyrics, Buddha, the *Tao te Ching*, and Brian Eno.

* When facing dark forces, shower them with love and recognize that all things are ONE. Do not fight or you make them stronger by encouraging duality.

* The word drugs is like the word God, in that both words have been used in so many ways that they're now virtually useless. Plus we have the doublethink aftertaste of the "War on Drugs", more accurately described as the War on Some Drugs or the War on Non-Corporate Drugs.

* Please be careful with drugs.

RESOURCES

Terence McKenna was the man. His books are great, especially *True Hallucinations*, and there are also tons of his lectures available online.

Ulysses – James Joyce

The Third Policeman – Flann O'Brien

The Tao Te Ching

The Upanishads

Promethea (5 volumes) – Alan Moore and J.H. Williams III

Quantum Psychology – Robert Anton Wilson

Kabbalah: An Illustrated Introduction to the Esoteric Heart of Jewish Mysticism – Tim Dedopulos

The Hero With a Thousand Faces – Joseph Campbell

The Portable Jung – Carl Jung, Joseph Campbell

Much of Grant Morrison's work, especially The Invisibles, Doom Patrol, The Filth, and Flex Mentallo.

Chapter 26:

FOOD

* "Mr. Leopold Bloom ate with relish the inner organs of beasts and fowls. He liked thick giblet soup, nutty gizzards, a stuffed roast heart, liver slices fried with crustrcrumbs, fried hencod's roes. Most of all he liked grilled mutton kidneys which gave his palate a fine tang of faintly scented urine." - *Ulysses*, James Joyce

* When you eat, the food also eats you, transferring your consciousness from faded overripe matter into fresh, sun-gilt astroform. How the memories and feeling of "I-ness" are transferred to the new matter is beyond my knowledge, but somehow it occurs. Energy on Earth comes from the sun, which goes into the plants as sunlight. We eat the plants or feed them to animals that we eat – either way we take in the light.

* Gormandizing energy from plant and animal sources, like writing, has gone far beyond the mere necessities that define it, becoming an art and source of multifarious pleasure three times a day (or more).

* Food opens caverns in the brain. Food is undeniably a media form.

* More than film, photography, or narrative, food brings a culture into us, literally becoming us by the process of digestion. When food is "unintentional" it can lead to chaotic and artistic mutations. More common, however, is a processed diet that weakens the mind and body. I don't think it's wrong to eat food you love and to love that food in return (even if it is a twinkie, it will be better digested than a "healthy" meal you don't want to eat). But when the diet is consistently common, mediocre, we send a message to ourselves that we don't care what we become, what form we take. I opened this section with that quote from James Joyce because even though I might not find the food described very appetizing if I saw it right in front of me, it is so lusciously described with an adoring eye that I know that Leopold Bloom would lovingly digest and enjoy it.

* Food that is randomly selected and not appreciated is insanity food, unintentional food, or diseased food. Better to eat food you love than force yourself onto a monstrous Atkins diet. I single out the Atkins diet because I've been subjected to the food on this plan by friends who tried to drag me along for the ride. I know my

body and my body likes starchy foods, the particular bane of Atkins, who tried to treat everyone as the same creature.

* So much of our day is arranged around food. We break our fast in the morning, bisect the day with lunch, and close out the evening with dinner, generally a time for reconnecting with loved ones who we parted with at the day's onset. Yet how many of us really respect mealtimes for the priceless moments they are? Even if you eat alone, it can be a time to relax and reconnect with the universe. Even when I've started work early in the morning I would always wake early enough to allow time to meditate and eat a calming breakfast. Sometimes this meant waking at 4:30 AM. This wasn't a decision I've ever regretted. If we are to be a conscious society it requires doing our best, choosing the best for ourselves and others, and moving beyond leftovers.

* In one acid trip I thought I experienced the life of a cow heading to a McDonald's bun and something inside me said THIS IS NOT RIGHT – COWS ARE PEOPLE, TOO. But that's not why I lean towards the vegetarian. It has more to do with the health benefits and state of the environment.

* But I think we also should expand our minds by expanding our diet, so when I eat out I am more flexible in my habits than at home. I lived in South Korea a year and meat dominates the meals there, especially beef, pork, and seafood. I went with the flow when I ate out with friends and co-workers, and my taste buds changed over the year.

* How is it two people can have different tastes (in food or anything)? How is it one person can have different tastes in the same lifetime? I don't think we're ever the same person twice.

* In America, we borrow cuisine from all over the world. But how often do we connect to the cultures we get the food from? This reminds me of buffalo hunters who took the animal's fur and left the rest of the buffalo behind to rot. I think we owe it to ourselves to fully immerse into the cultures we are eating, making it a communal experience, not a cannibalization.

* I've had food poisoning at least three times: at Chinese, Peruvian, and Mexican restaurants. When it hit I was beaten into bed for a day or two, shivering and burning convulsively, aching deep into my cell tissue and bones, creakly with painful agony. There is hell on Earth: food poisoning. Bowels deform and spit and hemorrhoids say hello and life doesn't seem worth the toll if this is what it takes. How could food trick me like that? But even with those experiences, I'll still keep

experimenting and eating at new restaurants. Cook the best food for yourself and your loved ones, and try new things. I mean this both literally and metaphorically. Life, after all, should taste good.

RESOURCES

Take cooking classes, go on wine tastings, chocolate tastings. Don't eat the same thing twice in a month. Be bold.

The Omnivore's Dilemma – Michael Pollan

No Reservations with Anthony Bourdain (TV show)

Chapter 27:

DANCE

* Dancing is the opposite of the internet.

* I could have easily included Dance with Games, Mood, or Music. It's important to those sections, but deserves its own section.

* Dance is the sister of Music and another potential candidate for oldest artform. To dance is to experience the full physicality of movement.

* Nobody is born a dance master, so take some classes. Any dance form. There is no wrong way to dance. However, there are better ways.

* Talking about dance is generally useless, so let's keep this chapter short.

RESOURCES

Wherever you are, there are people who will gladly teach you how to dance. You can start in private, in classes, watching youtube dance instruction videos, or whatever you feel comfortable with. Eventually you just have to get out there though, and stop caring what other people think of you. After all, what other people think of you is none of your business.

FRAMES

Chapter 28:

MYTHOLOGY

* Like many people in the West, my first thoughts when I hear mythology are images of Greek and Roman myths, akin to the films of Ray Harryhausen. And that certainly is a part of mythology. But what I'm talking about is much larger than that. I don't mean a specific culture's myths, but the collective stories and themes of all cultures, revealing the very structure of reality from the "divine comedy" of the smallest level of physics to the entire yogic unfolding of the cosmos. It is an understanding of the universal presence of story and music behind it all, the way the parts of a unified whole interact.

* The 20th century may have been the first time that a widespread awareness of mythology from outside the system became common. Certainly it's the first time that the average person had access to all the great wisdom traditions of the world.

* Joseph Campbell was the great explicator of these traditions. He combined the awareness of mythology at the microcosmic scale found in James Joyce with the understanding of symbols traced by Carl Jung.

* In Joyce, especially *Ulysses*, we see mythology functioning on an everyday level for a very ordinary man, Leopold Bloom, who is no more like Odysseus than I am like Hercules. Yet within Bloom we find a man facing daunting tasks and tests of courage as real as any demon or monster faced by the Greek heroes. Bloom does not encounter monsters in the physical sense, but people who act like monsters. These are forces that bewilder. They act upon the mind in similar ways, and myths act as a key to dealing with these challenges. We need to adapt myths to our own situation and epoch, but the answers are all there.

* "Myth is the mode of simultaneous awareness of a complex group of causes and effects." – Marshall McLuhan

* Mythology prepares us for the future, not by knowing what will happen, but by knowing how patterns recur.

* Each mythological system prepares you for different points in life, different temperaments. The Dreamtime of Australian Aboriginal Mythology, the Christian

God birthed into the form of a man, the Hindu structure of thousands of gods, the Buddhist recognition of the Oneness of All – each system has validity.

* Learning about mythology can lead to spiritual connection, but not necessarily. If studied in parallel with spiritual training, the mythological concepts take on greater depth and meaning.

* Joseph Campbell is best known for *The Hero With a Thousand Faces*, a hugely influential book on understanding mythology and fiction. This text transforms all heroes from every religion and story into a universal narrative of humanity's evolution. It clearly defines the stages that heroes go through, the ideals behind the hero, and offers insight into everyone's life.

* What is the difference between religion and mythology? "Mythology is everyone's religion except my own" – is the practical answer. It's easy to look at every belief system as flawed but one's own. Try to expand your understanding of reality and absorb different paradigms. There is truth everywhere, if you look for it.

RESOURCES

The Hero With a Thousand Faces – Joseph Campbell

The Masks of God (four volumes) – Joseph Campbell

The Portable Jung – Carl Jung (edited by Joseph Campbell)

Ulysses – James Joyce

Finnegans Wake – James Joyce

The Sandman (comics) – Neil Gaiman and artists

Chapter 29:

GAMES

* "Life is not a game."

* "Life is only a game."

* "…Merrily, merrily, merrily, merrily, life is but a dream."

* When you play a video game you may lose your "life." But when the game is over that loss of life means nothing. The experience of playing the game is all.

* Video games are becoming better and better metaphors for life. Will they one day be indistinguishable from life? From Pong to virtual reality is a mere drop in the well of human history.

* When you are born you put on a character. You play a while, and when the game is over your mom turns off the TV and makes you go outside.

* Play the game as hard as you can and do your best. But don't take it too seriously. We are playing first and foremost to have fun.

* We are seeing more win-win games. The win-lose games will remain, but with complexity our metaphors are shifting.

* The "opponent" is not other people but within ourselves when we do not live up to our highest self.

* A day without enigma probably isn't worth it.

* I once overheard a guy say that exercise (or was it sports?) are a physical way of thinking. I laughed it off since I thought sports were merely a way to keep the jocks busy from doing anything important, preferable to war. Later I began to take up more sports like fencing, martial arts, tennis, and I realized that sports are a physical way of thinking, as clunky as that sounds. I still think watching sports is a waste of my time, but playing them (especially one-on-one sports, my preference) is awesome and can augment your more cerebral skills.

* Chess is the one game everyone should learn to play. It's nearly as complex as life itself, and authors such as Lewis Carroll and Vladimir Nabokov have used the analogy well in their fiction.

* Gambling is a more painful version of other games. I understand why people do it and I am glad that I've never really gambled. I don't think I'd have the self-control to stop, so I'd rather not start at all.

* "It's no game" and "Life is not a game" are beliefs that you can choose to live by that will make life seem like it's not a game. Viewing life as a game does not mean we don't need to care about others and that nothing matters. On the contrary, it means we do our best to play. The goal of the game is chosen by the players. It is a collaborative open source game. The rules can be rewritten. The playing field can be redesigned.

* Viewing life in dramatic ultra-serious terms is not "right" or "wrong", but it limits the range of your emotions. Viewing life in game terms is more fun.

RESOURCES

Figments of Reality – Ian Stewart and Jack Cohen

The Cosmic Game – Stanislov Grof

Godel, Escher, Bach – Douglas Hofstadter

The Inner Game of Tennis – W. Timothy Gallwey

Three Moves Ahead – Bob Rice

The Game of Life and How to Play It – Florence Scovel Shinn

Chapter 30:

HUMOR

* "A perceptive or incisive joke can be more meaningful than platitudes between two covers." – Marshall McLuhan (and yes, this book is filled with annoying platitudes)

* If we aren't laughing and enjoying life, why are we here?

* Start laughing now.

* Make humor your perspective. Try to see the funny side of EVERYTHING.

* Humor is one of those things that most of us know is important, but which too often gets overlooked in the hustle and bustle of daily life. For anyone serious about maintaining a positive attitude and steering clear of depression, making humor a regular part of life is key.

* Hang around funny people.

* Absorb humor in your media – if you read or watch or listen to fiction, make it funny. Turn off the evening news or the morose war drama and listen to a stand-up comic or watch Flight of the Conchords or Arrested Development.

* Laughter helps the body heal.

* Help make others laugh. This doesn't mean memorizing a bunch of jokes and forcing others to listen. Humor is a perspective and that p.o.v. can be brought to anything.

* "Humor as a system of communications and as a probe of our environment – of what's really going on affords us our most appealing anti-environmental tool. It does not deal in theory, but in immediate experience, and is often the best guide to changing perceptions." – Marshall McLuhan

* One self-help author suggests making a list of things you have to do every day to consider the day a success. His list includes: work he loves, exercise, and something social. I suggest you make your list and give "humor" high priority.

You'll be surprised how quickly a daily dose of funny will inoculate you against depression and become an essential facet of your personality. Everything, if examined properly, is incredibly funny due to the inherent bliss and weirdness of the universe. Cultivate the ability to see humor and share it with others.

* Taking yourself too seriously is a fool's game that promotes ego attachment.

* When we laugh endorphins are released. Why wouldn't we laugh more? Like human touch and personal evolution, laughter is essential to a healthy organism.

* Humor transforms through time in response to trends and intelligence (I would say it's a type of intelligence). Seek it out, like food, and enjoy its many flavors.

* In my rush to get my information across I have written a totally humorless chapter.

Chapter 31:

LANGUAGE

* "The map is not the territory... The only usefulness of a map depends on similarity of structure between the empirical world and the map..." – Alfred Korzybski

* Keep expanding your vocabulary, always. New words make new worlds, allow new possibilities in thinking.

* Learn Braille. Braille allows words to move through your skin.

* Learn sign language.

* Learn foreign languages.

* "'Is', 'is.' 'is' — the idiocy of the word haunts me. If it were abolished, human thought might begin to make sense. I don't know what anything 'is'; I only know how it seems to me at this moment." – Robert Anton Wilson

* A philosophy is just an opinion. If you don't like a philosophy throw it away and find a better one. Or make your own.

* Strip away language and there are no contradictions.

* "From symbiosis to parasitism is a short step. The word is now a virus." – *The Ticket That Exploded*, William Burroughs

RESOURCES

The Job – William Burroughs

The Alphabet Versus the Goddess – Leonard Shlain

Quantum Psychology – Robert Anton Wilson

Science and Sanity – Alfred Korzybski

Chapter 32:

ZEN

* Zen wakes you up. Zen is always now. Zen may come through teaching, stories, meditation, or spontaneously.

* Zen doesn't care about definitions of zen. Zen is always happening, available anywhere.

* Kill the past, kill the future, kill the Buddha, kill the killing. There is no doer, no separation. Wake up!

* "When you can't see through your own actions, you are operating at your highest level." – *Zen Without Zen Masters*, Camden Benares

* Become what you are.

* Zen is hidden by all the programs people run in their heads. People are living through books, movies, music, language, advice, our visions of the future, our memories of the past, and the opinions of others. When we strip away all this garbage, zen is inevitable.

* I have nothing to say about zen, and neither does anyone.

RESOURCES

The Way of Zen – Alan Watts (and most Alan Watts, especially his live recordings)

Be Here Now – Ram Dass

The User Illusion – Tor Norretranders

Zen Without Zen Masters – Camden Benares

The Meme Machine – Susan Blackmore

Eckhart Tolle’s recordings

Chapter 33:

DESIGN

* Stop accepting the arbitrary as necessary. So much of the world is open to redesign.

* As innovative as current design is, I feel that most of it is going online or in art magazines or otherwise being locked away in museums. Why is the actual outside world still so bland? Why are all the cars mud colored? Why are all the lines so straight, the buildings so uniform in their boring textures?

* On the other hand, I like that more people are getting into crafts, homemade clothes etc. I just want MORE, MORE, MORE!!! This is 2010 (as I write this) – let's make it look like the future they said it was going to be.

* It's just my opinion but I think everything can be made more beautiful, inspiring, astonishing, fascinating. Question everything about design and admit that you are a designer, even if it's only your bedroom and your outfits you're designing.

* Nature is the master designer. Nature harmonizes and accepts asymmetry.

* The fact that government buildings are so bland is a clue that governments can only look to the past. Even airports and schools, potential gardens for beauty, are some of the most sterile and toxic environments I've ever seen.

* Brian Eno composed *Music for Airports* to make airports more beautiful. Why is that still such an original idea? Why do we accept crappy music filling the aisles and hallways?

* Start by redesigning your house with beauty and comfort in mind. Here's an easy one: Throw out the television. Learn some interior design, feng shui, color coordination etc and rethink your space, your walls, the images you project daily into your mind. Let the light in, get rid of drab colors, and look at nature if you want some hints.

* THE SIX SENSES OF THE CONCEPTUAL AGE (From Daniel H. Pink's *A Whole New Mind*):

1. Not just function but also DESIGN.
2. Not just argument but also STORY.
3. Not just focus but also SYMPHONY.
4. Not just logic but also EMPATHY.
5. Not just seriousness but also PLAY.
6. Not just accumulation but also MEANING.

RESOURCES

A Whole New Mind – Daniel H. Pink

Wordplay – John Langdon

Chapter 34:

OPEN SOURCE, P2P, AND PEER CULTURE

* "If you have an apple and I have an apple and we exchange these apples then you and I will still each have one apple. But if you have an idea and I have an idea and we exchange these ideas, then each of us will have two ideas." – George Bernard Shaw

* Open source software allows anyone to see the source code and alter that software, making improvements or adapting it to more specific environments for different users. It is usually free and is used by millions of people for numerous applications everyday. One of the best examples of open source software is Linux, a computer operating system available for anyone to modify. Because third-world countries can't afford the licensing fees for software like Windows, many use the Linux distribution Ubuntu, which allows them to use the internet and word-processing applications without paying hefty fees to Microsoft. While the idea of a product without traditional streams of profit might have been unthinkable fifty years ago, recent technologies allow and encourage phenomenon like open source software, so much so that the practice is spreading far beyond software, creating an open source culture.

* The obvious catalyst behind open source culture is the internet, which allows almost any piece of information to be appropriated, altered, and showcased within minutes. Any ten year-old with photo, music, or video editing software can instantly become an Andy Warhol. Much of this artistic borrowing and remixing violates copyrights, and corporations desperately seek for ways to stop it. But the impulse remains, and many recognize how these quickly evolving artistic mutations are vital contributions to the arts, and they would seek to encourage it. For this reason, things like open source software, copyleft, and the Creative Commons movement have come about. Artists can designate their work free of copyright and actively encourage others to use it as they will. No profit is involved in the traditional sense, although some artists may provide an option for donations. Many artists will provide their work for free on websites such as archive.org (The Internet Archive) and Myspace, aware that the added exposure may make them some extra fans, and any initial loss in profit will be replaced by word-of-mouth, concert attendance, and merchandising.

* Cory Doctorow released his young adult novel *Little Brother* for free online. In spite of this (or more likely, because of this), the print copy made it to No. 8 on the New York Times Bestseller List, children's chapter book section. He also encouraged readers to make and release free audiobook versions of the book.

* Open source culture can also be seen in a more instructional context. The most famous (and lamented) example is Wikipedia. A "wiki" is a collection of information that allows anyone to alter it. Many websites have wikis for instruction manuals and information that is best determined by its users. With Wikipedia, however, all information and perception is up for grabs, and with the entire universe potentially included, a very contradictory, jigsaw-like map is created. Wikipedia has no monolithic editor looking down on information to determine its "rightness." This is beneficial because it allows a more populous view on subjects, but can also contribute to an article's subjectivity, sloppiness, and incoherence. On the whole though, sites like Wikipedia are generally well put together considering how many minds are involved.

* How far the open source culture will extend remains to be seen. For example, pharmaceutical companies are often as protective of prescription drugs as the RIAA or the MPAA are of music and movies, charging hundreds of dollars for their drugs as long as they hold the patents. But generic equivalents can often be cheaply made. What price can we place on human lives? Protecting artistic rights is one thing, but withholding necessary medicine from people who are dying, solely because they can not afford to line the pockets of pharmaceutical companies, raises serious ethical issues. Profitability in medicine has been a huge political topic for years and was a major issue in the 2008 presidential election. It was also highlighted in the Michael Moore documentary *Sicko*. It is an issue that will not simply go away, and if open source culture continues to spread, the most humanitarian resolution possible can hopefully come about.

* At the heart of open source culture is the idea that all humanity is united, and that we can evolve, improve, and prosper most rapidly when we put aside the desire for fulfillment of the self alone, and recognize that the only way we will thrive is if we all have access to the necessary tools for life on Earth. Issues such as climate change are problems that affect us all, and withholding research and information for the sake of profit would be ridiculous. This is easy to see. It is harder to see how withholding access to software or cultural entertainments would jeopardize the planet as a whole. However, as the world became more globally connected in the 20th century, technological progress as a whole rapidly accelerated. Information strands combined in radical new ways, and creativity skyrocketed. This acceleration went hyperactive with the internet. I propose that if all

information was freely available to everyone that the innovations and benefits for humanity would be beyond anything we can imagine. There is already the $100 laptop for developing countries and open source software such as Ubuntu. But when will the wealth of humanity's cultural history be available for all? Should education really be based on wealth?

* I'm a big fan of torrents and think they're a great way of sharing information. That being the case, I realized when writing this book that it could very well be uploaded and shared online. And it would be nice to be paid for the work I put into it (there's donation info at the end of the book!)… but if I never saw a cent, you know what? I'd still be happy. I wrote this book to help everyone. I really believe that if others benefit, it will come around to everyone, including me.

* I like how torrent sites and other p2p communities function as communities. People thank each other, maintain healthy sharing ratios, and have a very tribal consciousness about the information they're sharing. Many sites don't even keep track of your share ratio, so there's no advantage to keeping it even. Many people really do like to share things with others.

* Chaos magick is essentially open source magic. You use whatever you want, borrow from here and there, throw away what doesn't work, and pass on your best stuff to your friends and peers.

* Transition periods tend to be sloppy and often violent (such as the French and American revolutions), but the transition we're seeing to open source culture is mainly getting messy in courtrooms, and lawsuits can't keep pace with pirating technologies. But even lawsuits are much gentler than previous historical upheaval. The civil disobedience of Thoreau will ultimately win out, since the majority is on the side of file sharing.

* Even the government sponsors its own brand of file sharing with libraries. The government already recognizes the importance of open access to information, it's just the delivery and payment that's being debated.

* I believe that free access to information will one day be recognized as a human right on par with sexual choice, religious freedom, and the right to explore one's consciousness. It will not be limited by wealth or position. It will give everyone an equal opportunity to succeed. It will bypass the caste systems and slavery of borders and promote universal understanding. Unfortunately, it will also allow more fraud, abuse, and international trafficking. I hope and believe the positives will outweigh the negatives.

* The true government is not called a government. The real decisions are already taking place via peer review and Wikipedia has more power than Congress in many ways.

* The leaders in history have rarely been the heads of government. The best definition of a leader I've heard is: Someone who influences others. In that sense Leonardo da Vinci and Charles Dickens were bigger leaders than any politician. Thanks to the internet we're seeing more and more little, invisible leaders, collaborating for big change. Everyone can have a voice, and if you have something worthwhile to say, you can be a leader.

* Websites like Couchsurfing, in which strangers allow strangers to stay in their home while traveling, would be all but impossible without peer review. With peer review, things like Couchsurfing are generally safe. It's kind of like a good version of *1984*.

* Language, while always open source and subject to evolution, has become even more open source now that anyone can publish, record, and film and put it online.

* One great thing about pirating content is that it's usually done digitally, reducing the amount of unnecessary CDs, DVDs, and books printed each year. Ebook readers will probably transform the publishing industry the way mp3 players demolished the music industry… and that's actually a good thing. This idea of an "industry" of art deserves to die.

* Governments are ways of organizing large groups of people. They are no more real than a "game" of football is real. There are people on a field of grass acting in a coordinated manner, but where is the game? Can you touch it? Where does it "go" when the clock runs out? Governments evolve and there is a long-term tendency toward greater opportunity to participate in government, becoming more "open source" as it were. It has never been easier to get involved in politics than today. Peer review and online reporting from independent individuals are the checks and balances of the 21st century.

RESOURCES

The Starfish and the Spider – Ori Brafman and Rod A. Beckstrom

Smart Mobs – Howard Rheingold

Free Culture – Lawrence Lessig

Downloading torrents is easy - try utorrent (http://www.utorrent.com/) or another bittorrent client. Once you have that installed, you can find content (music, movies, software etc) through countless sites. My favorite torrent trackers now are Demonoid (http://www.demonoid.me/) and Isohunt (http://isohunt.com/).

Chapter 35:

MAGIC

* This section is not about stage magic.

* In the 7th grade I found a book called *Norse Magic* (I don't recommend). I had read the *Dragonlance* books so it appealed to me. Could I really do things that others couldn't? My idea of this kind of magic was fireballs, levitation, D&D, Legend of Zelda. Was any of that stuff "real"?

* I tried some of the spells and techniques and nothing happened. Faak.

* But I kept on. Through Grant Morrison and Robert Anton Wilson I learned about chaos magick (with a "k"), which aimed to help you get results you wanted, whatever that might be. Morrison was big on sigils (a personalized symbol) so I tried those with mixed results. Wilson was big on language and NLP and I tried those techniques, also with mixed results.

* I also came across Aleister Crowley's work, which was confusing and often tedious. Too much ritual for my taste.

* Then I took psilocybin mushrooms. Things that weren't clear made much more sense.

* Defining or explaining magic is tricky. It is best experienced, and psychedelics are the most immediate key. Learn the basics of Hermetic Qabalah, read the books I suggest. But ultimately you just have to get out there and experience it. It evolves.

* Magic acts as a perspective on the world. It is not "against" science but encompasses science. Science, on the other hand, can not encompass magic. Magic accepts the paradox and impossibility of reality.

* Magic without a basis in other forms of knowledge, and without a cohesive structure of personal development/world betterment can be rather useless, like twiddling one's thumbs, or intellectual masturbation.

* Drugs can release enormous amounts of energy, which is why they manifest magical results more apparently. But that is precisely the reason to exercise more caution.

* "Magick is the Science and Art of causing Change to occur in conformity with Will." – Aleister Crowley

* I don't recommend Crowley as a portal to magic because he is shrouded with legends (partly encouraged by Crowley) and due to the difficulty of his work. He can be returned to at a later time. Reading him while young tends to promote idol worship in the man. He was a man with a thorough and wide understanding of magic, but not a god and not a great writer.

* Is there really a need for magic in the modern world? I would say yes, now more than ever. It is around you in millions of forms, and individuals need it just to assuage the influence of corporations, which use their own forms of magic, although they do not call it magic.

* Magic, meditation, and psychedelics are the best preparation for death.

* Although it can not be defined or explained, there is a path.

* At the gross level of being (waking consciousness), we are interacting with the beliefs of others and results are time-bound by those beliefs and the strength of your own beliefs. At the subtle level (dreaming consciousness, hallucinations), beliefs take more immediate effect in congruence with our understanding of reality. Boundaries dissolve and wills begin to unite. At the causal level of being (deep dreamless sleep, deep meditation) there is no separation between wills and identities. All possibilities exist and are potentiated at the causal level and flower into infinite realities. We are always choosing where we intersect with these realities, and magic is the knowledge of that choice.

* The mythologies of all cultures are the backdrop of magic. Understand Buddhism, Taoism, Hinduism, Aboriginal Dreamtime. See my section on mythology, and create your own mythology, your own internal angels and guides.

* Oracles such as the tarot and *I Ching* are mirrors into your soul. A mirror lets you see things otherwise outside your field of vision, and from a different but equally valid perspective.

* Anything can be connected to anything else, especially with the aid of magic. What is the connection between stage magic, "sorcery" magic, and the reality-bending magic I discuss in this chapter? That is for you to discover.

* Don’t take magic too seriously. The inherent nature of the universe is laughter, bliss. It’s a crazy chaos, but underneath it’s all game.

* As Sturgeon’s Law puts it, "Ninety percent of everything is crud." Books on magic are no exception. There are many, many poorly written books on magic out there. There are also some real gems.

RESOURCES

Illuminatus and anything by Robert Anton Wilson

The Invisibles – Grant Morrison

The Occult – Colin Wilson

Figments of Reality – Ian Stewart and Jack Cohen

The Moon and Serpent Bumper Book of Magic (forthcoming) – Alan and Steve Moore

Book of Lies: The Disinformation Guide to Magick and the Occult

CONCLUSION

The universe is infinite in all directions of space and time, so the idea of a conclusion is as ludicrous as that of a beginning. This book can lead you to paths you can walk forever.

In this book I've only included topics I've actually explored. There are many things I want to get to in the years to come. Please contact me with your thoughts, comments, corrections, and things to include in future editions of *Cheat Codes for Life*. Use this email: rexpop9@hotmail.com and put "Cheat Codes for Life" in the subject line. You can also make Paypal donations to that email, especially you nefarious souls who didn't pay for *Cheat Codes for Life*. If you got at least one good idea from this book, consider donating at least one good dollar.

Actually, I'm glad you found this book, however it came about, and hope that you'll give a copy to anyone who might benefit from its ideas.

You can also follow my blog, *NINJA-TEK*: http://cutup.livejournal.com/

Peace, my friend, and please: Love, laugh, learn, explore, and evolve!

"That we are no longer this poor little stranger and afraid in a world it never made. But that YOU ARE THIS UNIVERSE and you are creating it in every moment… Because it starts now, it didn't begin in the past, there was no past. See, if the universe began in the past when that happened it was now, but it's still now, and the universe is still beginning now, and it's trailing off like the wake of a ship from now, and as that wake fades out so does the past. You can look back there to explain things, but the explanation disappears. You'll never find it there… Things are not explained by the past, they are explained by what Happens Now. That creates the past, and it begins here… That's the birth of responsibility." – Alan Watts